Self-Justification Ex Machina

jpt4*

In memory of Dan E. Willard (1948–2023)

Abstract

Sebastian Oberhoff's essay *Incompleteness Ex Machina* proves Gödel's incompleteness theorems twice, once with sentences and once with programs, and concludes that Gödel's work divides into two parts: teaching arithmetic to compute, and the incompleteness theorems, which are victory laps. We look closely at the one step of the second theorem that Oberhoff takes "with some faith": that a system which can watch any run of its own proof-searcher can also prove, of the run that never happens, that it would have seen it. Willard's self-justifying axiom systems are what remains when that step is withheld. His 2005 system $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$, for semantic tableaux and for tableau lists with one-quantifier-block lemmas, proves every true Σ_1-class sentence of its language and takes its own Level(1) consistency as an axiom. Willard proved, in ordinary metamathematics, that it is consistent whenever the Π_1-class theorems of its base theory are true. His 2001 system $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ asserts the weaker Level(0−) consistency and is consistent under the analogous hypothesis of regular consistency. Under these hypotheses both systems are honest. They obey the first incompleteness theorem when the base theory also proves the Π_1-class theorems of Peano Arithmetic in the system's own language: PA+, with Willard's 2005 function symbols, or PAX, with his 2001 ones. We state everything at the granularity self-justification needs (language, deduction method, consistency notion, proof predicate, encoding), fixing the conventions Willard leaves open, and retell his 2005 consistency proof as a program in Oberhoff's case format. We then show that the faith step fails in two ways. In its uniform form it fails for both systems for a plain reason: a proof from their universal axioms can only produce witnesses that grow linearly in its inputs, so they cannot even prove that every number has a written name. At the Gödel sentence itself the faith step says that if the Gödel sentence is provable, then so is the Σ_1 statement that the proof-searcher halts. In a system that proves its own Level(1) consistency, with a correct bounded proof predicate, our fixed point and a pairing of each sentence with its negation, this step is provably equivalent to the Gödel sentence, hence unprovable. Willard's 2005 system meets these conditions. Willard's 2005 Theorem 6 then shows the faith being bought: a bounded transcript form of the step is a Π_1-class theorem of PA+, and one axiom asserting that a single large number exists makes the system inconsistent. Its fourth step, as printed, confuses two sentences. We sketch a repair, so at this granularity the theorem has the status of a sketch. Gödel's work, viewed this way, splits into three parts, not two.

Another way to motivate the axiom system IS is to consider a philosopher's response to the question of whether multiplication is a function. His first answer would likely be "of course yes". But if one then asked the philosopher to construct a sequence of natural numbers $a_0, a_1, a_2, a_3, \ldots$ where $a_0 \geq 2$ and $a_{i+1} = (a_i)^2$, a hedge would quickly follow because a_n requires at least 2^n bits. The expected response would then be that "multiplication is a function in theory but not always in practice". — Dan Willard, SUNY Albany TR 93-10, p. 6

*Revision of 25 October 2026, prepared with Claude (Anthropic) in the `sjas` research repository. Willard's results are cited from that repository's codification of his papers (`nachlass/codification/codified-sjas.md`), with page numbers referring to the author copies held there and proof statuses as recorded there.

1 Victory Laps

Oberhoff's essay [Oberhoff 2018] does something deceptively simple. It writes out Gödel's first incompleteness theorem, Rosser's improvement of it, and the second incompleteness theorem as explicit case analyses. Then it replaces Gödel's sentence G ("I am not provable") by $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ = «$\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ doesn't halt», where P is the program

```
P(A) {
  for s ∈ all possible strings {
    if s is a proof in 𝓕 that A(A) doesn't halt {
      halt;
    }
  }
}
```

and observes that each case analysis can be copied almost word for word. The punchline (his §5) is that $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is G wearing Clark Kent's glasses: $\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ is searching $\mathcal{F}$'s proofs for a proof of $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$, so $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ says "I am not provable". His moral (§6) is a refactoring. The hard part of Gödel's work was teaching arithmetic to compute, packaged as

> **Theorem 7** (Turing Completeness of Elementary Arithmetic). *Every formal system capable of reasoning about elementary arithmetic can also reason about algorithms,*

which Oberhoff leaves "to smarter people". The incompleteness theorems themselves are victory laps.

For the first incompleteness theorem we accept this completely. This essay is about the second. Its proof in [Oberhoff 2018] contains exactly one step that Oberhoff marks as taken on trust (Theorem 6, third step):

> Now we simply observe (with some faith) that there wasn't actually anything in the reasoning we used to prove this that we couldn't carry out just as well in $\mathcal{F}$.

For the systems Oberhoff has in mind, that faith is well placed. But some formal systems can reason about algorithms in every sense the first theorem needs, and for them the faith is misplaced: they prove their own consistency, and, by theorems of Willard's proved in ordinary metamathematics, they are consistent whenever their base theory has a bounded proof predicate and true Π_1-class theorems. For 2001 this is Willard's "regular consistency" (2001, p. 12); Theorem J gives the two cases exactly. Dan Willard constructed them in papers from 1993 to 2020 [Willard TR 93-10, Willard 2001, Willard 2005, Willard 2006a, Willard 2020]. (We cite Willard's papers by year, as in the bibliography: "2002a" is [Willard 2002a].) This essay tells their story in Oberhoff's language. Our headline is that the faith step is not part of the victory lap. It is a third part of Gödel's work, and it has a price.

The standard of precision. Oberhoff's essay is a paper proof at the granularity the second incompleteness theorem needs: for Peano Arithmetic and its relatives, it does not matter which language, which proof system, which notion of consistency or which Gödel numbering one picks, since the system proves that the choices agree. Self-justification lives exactly where those choices stop agreeing. Willard's systems are self-justifying for one deduction method and inconsistent for another, consistent at one consistency level and not at the next, and his proofs measure Gödel numbers in bits. An exegesis that is to have the proof status of Oberhoff's must therefore fix every one of these parameters, and say where a result depends on them. Section 2 fixes them. Throughout,

"Willard proved" means that the result is printed with a complete proof (status `full`); other statuses are named where they occur. Results labelled *ours* are proved here.

2 Conventions

Configurations. Following Willard, a *configuration* (α, D) is an axiom system α together with a deduction method D; $\alpha \vdash_D \varphi$ means that φ has a D-proof from α. D is *α-sound* if $\alpha \vdash_D \varphi$ implies that φ holds in every model of α, and *α-complete* if the converse holds (2001, §7, p. 37). All deduction methods in this essay (Hilbert-style deduction, semantic tableaux, and Willard's tableau lists below) are sound and complete in this sense. They differ in proof *length*, and self-justification is a phenomenon of length.

Fact A (Willard 2001, Lemma 7.1B, p. 37, `full`)**.** *If D is α-sound and α-complete, $\alpha \vdash_D \varphi$, $\alpha \vdash_D \psi$, and $\varphi \wedge \psi \supset \chi$ holds in every model of α, then $\alpha \vdash_D \chi$.*

So the theorems of (α, D) are closed under logical consequence. What is not closed is the size of proofs: for a cut-free D, Willard notes, the combined proof "could then correspond to a bit string more than exponentially larger than the combined lengths of the three initial proofs" (2001, p. 38, text layer).

Languages. Three languages occur.

- The language of arithmetic, with 0, successor, $+$ and $\times$, and the usual classes Δ_0, Π_1, Σ_1.
- Willard's 2001 language: the seven *grounding functions* (truncated subtraction, integer division, predecessor, maximum, logarithm, root, and *Count*, all *non-growth*: $F(\vec{a}) \leq \max(\vec{a})$) and one constant symbol $\bar{n}$ for every natural number n (2001, pp. 9–10). Its classes are written Δ_0^-, Π_1^-, Σ_1^-. Addition is not a function symbol; Group-1 of IS(A) asserts its totality by the Π_2^- axiom $\forall x \, \forall y \, \exists z \; z - x = y$ (2001, Eq. 6).
- Willard's 2005 *U-Grounding* language: six grounding functions plus the growth functions $+$ and $\mathit{Double}(x) = x + x$, eight function symbols in all, with constants $\bar{c}_0$, $\bar{c}_1$ for 0 and 1 (2005, §2, p. 4, and §3, p. 8). Every $n \geq 2$ is named by a term $\overline{n}$, Willard's "U-Grounded Binary Representation", with at most $2 \log_2 n$ occurrences of $+$ and *Double* applied to 1 (p. 4, where the overline is Willard's notation). Its classes are Δ_0^*, Π_1^*, Σ_1^*; bounded quantifiers have the form $\forall v \leq t$ and $\exists v \leq t$ (p. 5). A negation written in front of unbounded quantifiers yields a sentence in neither class: for a proper Σ_1^* sentence Υ, "$\neg\Upsilon$" is "technically viewed ... as not constituting a formal Π_1^* sentence", although it is logically equivalent to one (Remark 5, II, p. 27, text layer). Multiplication is not a function symbol; its graph $M(x, y, z)$ is a Δ_0^* formula (2005, Eq. 4), so the system knows multiplication's algebra but not its totality. Multiplication by any fixed constant is total, through iterated addition; what is withheld is the *uniform* operation $x \cdot y$ (codified statement §3.1).

We write "bounded", "Π_1-class" and "Σ_1-class" for whichever of these classes is in force. A bar over a number, $\bar{n}$, denotes the constant for n in the 2001 language and the term $\overline{n}$ in the 2005 language; no argument below needs a constant for every number.

Consistency notions. For a configuration (α, D), Willard distinguishes (2005, p. 5): *Level(0−)*: there is no D-proof of $0 = 1$ from α; *Level(1)*: there is no Π_1^* sentence Ψ such that both Ψ and $\neg\Psi$ have D-proofs from α. "All the definitions of consistency, from Level(0-) up to Level(n) for any n, are equivalent to each other under strong enough models of arithmetic. However, many weak axiom systems do not have a mathematical strength to recognize this equivalence" (2005, p. 6, text layer). Willard's rule for choosing among them: "it is desirable to use the weakest possible definition ... when one is seeking to generalize the Second Incompleteness Theorem. On the other hand, the opposite is true when one seeks to develop 'boundary-case exceptions' " (2002c, p. 2, text layer). This is why his negative results below use Level(0−) and his positive ones Level(1).

Arithmetization. For each configuration in this essay, $\mathrm{Prf}_\alpha^D(x, y)$ ("y is the Gödel number of a D-proof from α of the sentence with Gödel number x") is a bounded formula, and $\mathrm{Prov}_\alpha^D(x) := \exists y\, \mathrm{Prf}_\alpha^D(x, y)$. That this and the other syntactic predicates below (substitution, Pair, the Prenex* rewriting) have bounded definitions in Willard's languages is his arithmetization of syntax. It runs through Wrathall's characterization of the linear-time hierarchy by bounded formulas (2001, Theorems C.1–C.2, `sketch`; Theorem C.3, `full` given them; 2005, p. 10). It is the part of Gödel's work that Oberhoff packages as his Theorem 7, transposed to languages without total multiplication. We take it as given, with that status. Oberhoff's «A(A) halts», for the proof-searching programs P, B, C of this essay, is formalized as "the search succeeds": an existential statement about Prf, not about execution traces.

Encoding. We fix the Gödel encoding. Proofs are encoded as in 2005, Appendix A (pp. 39–40): a string of six-bit bytes read as an integer in base 64, each of the 24 symbols coded between 32 and 55 (so with leading bit 1), and a tableau list encoded as the concatenation of its components. A sentence is numbered by the value of its own byte string, the convention 2001 states (Appendix B, p. 51); 2005's Appendix A encodes only proofs, and we extend it in the same way. The first byte is the highest place, the natural reading of "an integer written in base 64". Willard does not say otherwise, and we fix it. Two consequences are used below. A string of N bytes that begins with a symbol byte has value at least $32 \cdot 64^{N-1}$; every proof and every sentence begins with one. And a sentence that occurs in a proof has a Gödel number no larger than the proof's, since a contiguous substring of a base-64 numeral has no larger value. Every axiom used in a tableau occurs in it as a node (p. 6: the nodes other than the root "are either axioms of α or deductions from higher nodes").

Prenex form. A semantic tableau proof of Φ is a closed tree whose root "stores the sentence $\neg\Phi$ (rewritten in Prenex* normal form)", a Prenex* sentence being a Π_i^* or Σ_i^* sentence (2005, p. 6). So whether a tree proves Φ depends on Φ only through that root. Willard does not fix the rewriting, and we fix it. For a Prenex* sentence $\Theta = Q_1 v_1 \ldots Q_k v_k\, \delta$ with δ bounded, let $\mathrm{dual}(\Theta) := \bar{Q}_1 v_1 \ldots \bar{Q}_k v_k\, \neg\delta$, with each quantifier exchanged for the other. Let $\mathrm{pnx}(\Theta) := \Theta$, and $\mathrm{pnx}(\neg\Theta) := \mathrm{dual}(\mathrm{pnx}(\Theta))$. Willard's arguments use only that the root is a Prenex* sentence equivalent to $\neg\Phi$, with the class and validity level that sentence has (Remark 5, I, p. 27; the proof of Theorem 2, pp. 23–26, and Appendix B). So they hold under this convention, and he adds that "All our results will also hold if we drop the Prenex* requirement" (p. 7, `stated-only`). The convention has the property we need: for a Prenex* sentence Φ,

$$\mathrm{pnx}(\neg\neg\Phi) = \mathrm{dual}(\mathrm{dual}(\Phi)) = \mathrm{pnx}(\neg\, \mathrm{dual}(\Phi)),$$

so the syntactic negation $\neg\Phi$ and the Prenex* sentence $\mathrm{dual}(\Phi)$ have exactly the same tableau proofs. They have the same tableau-list proofs too, since a list proves the conclusion of its last component (p. 7).

Pairing a sentence with its negation. Willard's consistency axiom uses a bounded formula $\mathrm{Pair}(x, y)$ for "x is the Gödel number of a Π_1^* sentence and y is x's negation" (2005, p. 9), "the sentence that represents the negation of x's formal statement" (p. 34). His text uses two candidates for y. Eq. (28) writes $\mathrm{Pair}(\ulcorner f \urcorner, \ulcorner \neg f \urcorner)$, the string $\neg f$, which is in neither class (p. 5, and p. 26, footnote 3: "neither Σ_1^* nor Π_1^* because a negation symbol appears to the left of its unbounded quantifiers"). His proof of Theorem 1 uses "the Σ_1^* theorem that is Φ's negation" (p. 20), that is, $\mathrm{dual}(\Phi)$. We fix $\mathrm{Pair}(x, y)$ to hold when x codes a Π_1^* sentence Φ and y codes a sentence θ with $\mathrm{pnx}(\neg\theta) = \mathrm{pnx}(\neg\neg\Phi)$: a sentence whose tableau proofs are exactly those of $\neg\Phi$. Both of Willard's candidates qualify, and under the convention above they have the same proofs.

The Gödel sentence and the halting sentence. Let $\mathrm{SUBST}_0(g, h)$ be a bounded formula defining the graph of substitution: h is the code of the sentence obtained by substituting the numeral of g into the formula coded by g. Use it in least-witness form,

$$\mathrm{SUBST}(g, h) := \mathrm{SUBST}_0(g, h) \wedge \forall h' \leq h\, [h' = h \vee \neg \mathrm{SUBST}_0(g, h')],$$

which is bounded and, in the standard model, holds exactly when SUBST_0 does. Let n be the Gödel number of

$$\Gamma(g) := \forall x\, \forall h\, \big[\mathrm{SUBST}(g, h) \supset \neg \mathrm{Prf}_\alpha^D(h, x)\big],$$

and let $\ddot{\mathsf{G}} := \Gamma(\bar{n})$ and $c := \ulcorner \ddot{\mathsf{G}} \urcorner$. $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is a Π_1-class sentence, and $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$ is a true bounded sentence. The *halting sentence* is

$$\mathsf{H} := \mathrm{dual}(\ddot{\mathsf{G}}) = \exists x\, \exists h\, \neg\big[\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, h) \supset \neg \mathrm{Prf}_\alpha^D(h, x)\big],$$

«$\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halts»: some x is a proof of the sentence that substitution produces. It is Σ_1-class, and $\mathrm{Pair}(\bar{c}, \bar{c}')$ is a true bounded sentence for $c' := \ulcorner \mathsf{H} \urcorner$.

Our $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ differs from Willard's fixed point (2001, Eq. 63, p. 38) in two respects, both ours. It has no bound $h \leq x$, as Willard's own bounded Gödel sentence $\mho$ has none (2005, Eq. 24, p. 33). And its substitution formula is in least-witness form. Together these make the fixed point provable from trichotomy alone, with no encoding hypothesis and no inherited uniqueness theorem:

Fact B (Fixed point; after Willard 2001, proof of Theorem 7.2, p. 39)**.** *Let D be α-sound and α-complete, let Prf_α^D be bounded, and let α prove the true bounded sentence $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$. Then*

$$\alpha \vdash_D \ddot{\mathsf{G}} \supset \forall y\, \neg \mathrm{Prf}_\alpha^D(\bar{c}, y). \tag{FP$\Rightarrow$}$$

If α also proves trichotomy at $\bar{c}$, $\forall h\, (h \leq \bar{c} \vee \bar{c} \leq h)$, then α proves the uniqueness sentence (U) $\forall h\, [\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, h) \supset h = \bar{c}]$ and

$$\alpha \vdash_D \ddot{\mathsf{G}} \leftrightarrow \forall y\, \neg \mathrm{Prf}_\alpha^D(\bar{c}, y). \tag{FP}$$

Proof. (FP$\Rightarrow$): $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ instantiated at $x = y$, $h = \bar{c}$, with $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$, gives $\neg \mathrm{Prf}(\bar{c}, y)$. So $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$ implies (FP$\Rightarrow$) in every structure.

(U): let $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, h)$. If $h \leq \bar{c}$, the second conjunct of $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$ at $h' = h$ gives $h = \bar{c}$ or $\neg \mathrm{SUBST}_0(\bar{n}, h)$, and the first conjunct of $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, h)$ excludes the latter. If $\bar{c} \leq h$, the second conjunct of $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, h)$ at $h' = \bar{c}$ gives $\bar{c} = h$ or $\neg \mathrm{SUBST}_0(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$, and the first conjunct of $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$ excludes the latter. So trichotomy and $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$ imply (U) in every structure.

(FP$\Leftarrow$): given x and h with $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, h)$, (U) gives $h = \bar{c}$, and the hypothesis gives $\neg \mathrm{Prf}(\bar{c}, x)$.

Each implication therefore follows in every model of α from theorems of α, and Fact A, applied repeatedly, gives its D-proof. □

H is logically equivalent to the syntactic negation $\neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$, and Fact A gives $\alpha \vdash_D \neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}} \leftrightarrow \mathsf{H}$, but that alone does not give $\alpha \vdash_D \mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner\neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}\urcorner) \leftrightarrow \mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner\mathsf{H}\urcorner)$: Prov is sensitive to codes, and such an equivalence is a derivability condition, the very thing in question. What our conventions give instead is that $\neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ and H have the same proofs in the standard model, and that Pair pairs $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ with both.

Relative consistency. Every consistency result in this essay, Willard's and ours, is a theorem of ordinary metamathematics proved under a hypothesis, typically that the Π_1-class theorems of a base theory A are true. That hypothesis is not decidable, and no system here is "proved consistent" outright. How strong a metatheory these proofs need is a separate question, which this essay does not address. An example is whether Willard's consistency theorem is provable in elementary arithmetic from uniform Π_1 reflection for A.

3 Where the Faith Lives

Here is the first half of Oberhoff's proof that $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is undecidable (his §4, a second proof of his Theorem 4):

Suppose $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is provable:
Or $\neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ isn't provable:

⇒ Because $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is provable $\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ will eventually find such a proof after some sequence of steps which we can write out in $\mathcal{F}$.

⇒ Because this sequence leads to a terminal state this gives a proof of «$\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halts» $= \neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$. ↯

Theorem 6 asks $\mathcal{F}$ to run this argument on itself. Fix a configuration $(\mathcal{F}, D)$ and write Prov for $\mathrm{Prov}^D_{\mathcal{F}}$. As statements that $\mathcal{F}$ must prove, the argument has three steps.

(1) $\mathsf{H} \supset \mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c})$: «if $\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halts, then $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is provable». This is (FP⇐), contraposed. It is not literally trivial: H speaks of "the sentence h with $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, h)$", and identifying h with $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ needs the uniqueness sentence (U), which costs trichotomy (Fact B).

(2) $\mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}) \supset \mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}\,')$, where $c' = \ulcorner\mathsf{H}\urcorner$: «if $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is provable, then «$\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halts» is provable». This is the step "$\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ will eventually find such a proof after some sequence of steps which we can write out in $\mathcal{F}$". Inside $\mathcal{F}$ it reads: *for every proof s of $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ there is a proof that $\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halts*, namely the proof that exhibits s and checks it.

(3) $\mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}) \wedge \mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}\,') \supset \mathit{Inc}$, where *Inc* is the negation of the consistency statement in use. For Level(1), whose statement is $\forall x\,\forall y\,\forall p\,\forall q\,\neg[\mathrm{Pair}(x,y) \wedge \mathrm{Prf}(x,p) \wedge \mathrm{Prf}(y,q)]$ with Pair as in §2 (2005, Eq. 6, p. 9), step (3) follows from this statement and the true bounded sentence $\mathrm{Pair}(\bar{c}, \bar{c}\,')$ by Fact A. For Level(0−) it is a formalized combination of two proofs into a proof of $0 = 1$, which for a cut-free D is the expensive construction Fact A warns about.

Chaining (1)–(3) gives $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \mathsf{H} \supset \mathit{Inc}$, that is, $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \neg\mathit{Inc} \supset \ddot{\mathsf{G}}$: «$\mathcal{F}$ is consistent ⇒ $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$», which is what Theorem 6 needs.

The only step that asks $\mathcal{F}$ to know something substantial about itself is (2). In the first incompleteness theorem, "which we can write out in $\mathcal{F}$" was a fact *about* $\mathcal{F}$, established by us from outside: we are handed a halting run and we produce the proof. In the second theorem it has to be a theorem *of* $\mathcal{F}$, stated for every s at once. The two deserve separate names.

Definition C (Watching)**.** $(\mathcal{F}, D)$ *watches* if $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \sigma$ for every true Σ_1-class sentence σ of its language.

Definition D (Knowing that one watches)**.** $(\mathcal{F}, D)$ *knows that it watches* at a sentence σ if $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \sigma \supset \mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \sigma \urcorner)$. It *knows that it watches* if it does so at every Σ_1-class sentence.

A program halts if and only if a Σ_1 sentence about it is true, so watching is external Σ_1-completeness, and knowing that one watches is formalized Σ_1-completeness, sentence by sentence. Section 4 adds its uniform version, with a free variable. The third Hilbert–Bernays–Löb derivability condition [Hilbert–Bernays 1939, Löb 1955], $\mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \varphi \urcorner) \supset \mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \varphi \urcorner) \urcorner)$, is the instance at the Σ_1 sentences $\sigma = \mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \varphi \urcorner)$, the halting statements of proof searches.

Lemma E (ours)**.** *Let $(\mathcal{F}, D)$ watch, with D $\mathcal{F}$-sound and $\mathcal{F}$-complete and $\mathrm{Prf}^D_{\mathcal{F}}$ correct in the standard model (it holds of (h, x) exactly when x codes a D-proof from $\mathcal{F}$ of the sentence coded h).*

(a) $(\mathcal{F}, D)$ knows that it watches at every true *Σ_1-class sentence.*

(b) If (FP) holds, step (2) is $\mathcal{F}$-provably equivalent to knowing that one watches at H: $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D (2) \leftrightarrow [\mathsf{H} \supset \mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}\,')]$.

Proof. (a) Let σ be true. Then $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \sigma$ by watching, so a D-proof of σ exists, $\mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \sigma \urcorner)$ is a true Σ_1-class sentence, and watching gives $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \sigma \urcorner)$. Since $\mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \sigma \urcorner) \supset (\sigma \supset \mathrm{Prov}(\ulcorner \sigma \urcorner))$ is valid, Fact A gives the implication. (b) (FP) and $\mathsf{H} \leftrightarrow \neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ are theorems of $\mathcal{F}$, so by soundness every model of $\mathcal{F}$ satisfies $\mathsf{H} \leftrightarrow \mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c})$. The two implications differ only by this replacement in the antecedent, so their equivalence holds in every model of $\mathcal{F}$, and Fact A gives the D-proof. □

So the faith step is not a claim about runs that happen. Those a watching system sees, and Lemma E(a) gives it the knowledge for free. The faith is a claim about a run that does not happen: if $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is true, H is false, and step (2) asserts that *had* $\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halted, $\mathcal{F}$ would have seen it.

Here is what each result of [Oberhoff 2018] uses:

Result in [Oberhoff 2018]	Assumes about $\mathcal{F}$	Watches	Knows it watches
Thm 4 (G1 via halting)	honest; complete (for contradiction)	—	—
§4, $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ undecidable	consistent; honest in case 2	case 1	—
Thm 5 (Rosser, via B)	consistent	both cases	—
Thm 6 (G2)	consistent	yes	step (2)

Theorem 4 needs only that $\mathcal{F}$ can *state* halting facts honestly; the search does the rest. Case 2 of the §4 argument uses only that $\mathcal{F}$'s Σ_1 theorems are true. Rosser's case 2 also uses a Π_1 fact, that a run which has entered `while true {}` never leaves it; Oberhoff's footnote 12: "Any formal system capable of reasoning about algorithms can prove that 'while true {}' runs forever; otherwise it ought to be ashamed of itself." Apart from that, every result in the essay except the second incompleteness theorem uses watching and nothing more. The classical proof of the second theorem runs through the derivability conditions; the computational retelling shows what the third condition *says*.

4 Transcripts Are Bigger Than Runs

Why should knowing be harder than watching? The natural proof of step (2) takes a proof s of $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ and produces the proof t of «$\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halts» that exhibits s and checks it. In a language whose only growth functions are $+$ and *Double*, exhibiting s costs a term, and terms are expensive.

Lemma F (ours)**.** *In Willard's 2005 language and encoding, every semantic tableau proof that contains a closed term of value $v \geq 2$ has Gödel number greater than v^5.*

Proof. A closed term with L function symbols built from $\bar{c}_0$, $\bar{c}_1$ has value at most 2^L: non-growth functions do not increase the maximum of their arguments, and $+$ and *Double* at most double it. This is the doubling estimate of case (c) in Willard's proof of Lemma 1 (2005, p. 24), applied to a term with no parameters. So a term of value v has $L \geq \log_2 v$ function symbols. The U-Length of a node is the number of U-Grounding function symbols in its sentence; its U-Depth is its own U-Length plus the U-Lengths of all its ancestors; and the U-Height of the tree is the largest U-Depth of a leaf (p. 22). So the node containing the term has U-Depth at least L. If that node is a leaf, the U-Height is at least its U-Depth. If not, a leaf below it has a U-Depth at least as large, since the nodes in between add non-negative U-Lengths. Either way the tree has U-Height at least L. Willard's Eq. (20) (p. 26) is U-Height$(p) < \frac{1}{5}\log_2 p$, which, he says, Appendix A's encoding "as well as any other reasonable encoding methodology, will clearly satisfy" (text layer). Hence $\log_2 p > 5L \geq 5\log_2 v$. □

So the transcript t of step (2) is bigger than the fifth power of the run s it records, and the natural proof of step (2) asks $\mathcal{F}$ to believe that $s \mapsto t$ is defined everywhere. Willard's systems cannot believe that of any function that outgrows every linear one. The reason lies in how a proof from universal axioms produces the numbers it claims exist.

Proposition G (Linear witnesses; ours)**.** *Let $\mathcal{F}$ be a set of sentences of Willard's 2005 language, each bounded or Π_1^*-class, all true in the standard model, and let $\delta(\vec{x},\vec{y})$ be bounded. If $\mathcal{F} \vdash \forall\vec{x}\,\exists\vec{y}\,\delta(\vec{x},\vec{y})$ (in first-order logic, hence by any sound deduction method), then there is a natural number k such that for all $\vec{x}$ some $\vec{y} \leq k\,(x_1 + \cdots + x_m + 1)$ satisfies δ. The same holds in Willard's 2001 language for a set of true sentences, each bounded or Π_1^--class, together with the axiom that addition is total.*

Proof. The 2005 case. Write $|\vec{x}|$ for $x_1 + \cdots + x_m + 1$, and $\bar{k}\cdot t$ for the term $t + \cdots + t$ with k summands. Suppose that no k works. Then for each k some $\vec{x}$ has no witness $\vec{y} \leq k|\vec{x}|$. So each finite subset of $\mathrm{Th}(\mathbb{N}) \cup \{\forall\vec{y} \leq \bar{k}\cdot|\vec{c}|\ \neg\delta(\vec{c},\vec{y}) : k \in \mathbb{N}\}$, with new constants $\vec{c}$, is satisfied in $\mathbb{N}$ by interpreting $\vec{c}$ as such an $\vec{x}$ for the largest k involved. By compactness there is a model M of $\mathrm{Th}(\mathbb{N})$ with elements $\vec{a}$ such that $M \models \forall\vec{y} \leq \bar{k}\cdot|\vec{a}|\ \neg\delta(\vec{a},\vec{y})$ for every $k \in \mathbb{N}$. Let

$$I := \{\, z \in M : z \leq \bar{k}\cdot|\vec{a}| \text{ for some } k \in \mathbb{N} \,\}.$$

The following facts hold because the sentences expressing them are true in $\mathbb{N}$, hence in M: $\leq$ is transitive, so I is an initial segment; $\bar{n} \leq \bar{n}\cdot u$ for $u \geq 1$, so I contains every $\bar{n}$; and $x \leq \bar{i}\cdot u$, $y \leq \bar{j}\cdot u$ imply $x + y \leq \overline{i+j}\cdot u$ and $\mathit{Double}(x) \leq \overline{2i}\cdot u$, so I is closed under $+$ and *Double*. The six non-growth functions satisfy $F(\vec{z}) \leq \max(\vec{z})$ (2005, p. 4, as a true sentence of each), so I is closed under them too. Hence I is a substructure of M and an initial segment. A bounded formula therefore has the same truth value in I as in M at arguments from I: its terms take the same values, and its quantifiers range over initial segments of I. A bounded sentence of $\mathcal{F}$ is true in M, hence in I. A Π_1^*-class sentence $\forall\vec{z}\,\beta(\vec{z})$ of $\mathcal{F}$ is true in M, so β holds at every tuple from I, in M and hence in I. So $I \models \mathcal{F}$, hence $I \models \forall\vec{x}\,\exists\vec{y}\,\delta$, and some $\vec{y} \in I$ satisfies $\delta(\vec{a},\vec{y})$ in I, hence in M. But $\vec{y} \leq \bar{k}\cdot|\vec{a}|$ for some $k \in \mathbb{N}$, against the choice of $\vec{a}$.

The 2001 case. Addition is not a function symbol there, but its graph $z \mathbin{\dot{-}} x = y \wedge x \leq z$ is a bounded formula, and the true sentences that it is total (2001, Eq. 6) and single-valued hold in every model of $\mathrm{Th}(\mathbb{N})$. So expand $\mathbb{N}$ and M by the function it defines, and write the bounds $\bar{k}\cdot|\vec{x}|$ with it. Each such bound is expressible by a bounded formula through the graph. The argument above then runs verbatim: I is closed under the defined addition and under the grounding functions, which are non-growth; it contains every constant $\bar{n}$; and the bounded and Π_1^--class sentences of $\mathcal{F}$ hold in I. The axiom that addition is total holds in I, because for $x, y \in I$ the element $z = x + y$ lies in I and satisfies $z \mathbin{\dot{-}} x = y$. ↯ □

The constant k can be large. For intuition, though the proof above does not need it: Herbrand's theorem would present the witnesses as terms, and a term of depth d built from $+$, *Double* and non-growth functions is at most 2^d times its largest argument. So k is like 2^d: exponential in the proof, but fixed once the proof is. The input $\vec{x}$ ranges over all numbers, so the witnesses grow linearly in the input, with the proof's size in the constant. Willard's own engine makes the same comparison from the other side: no proof can name a number much larger than its own Gödel number. With multiplication as a total function, a term of depth d can grow like x^{2^d} in its input and name numbers like 2^{2^d}. That is the reason Willard's construction fails there (§9).

Write $\mathrm{Num}(x, y)$ for a bounded formula saying that y is the Gödel number of the sentence $\bar{x} = \bar{x}$. For a bounded formula $\delta(x)$, say that $(\mathcal{F}, D)$ *knows uniformly that it watches* δ if $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \forall x\,[\delta(x) \supset \exists y\,\exists q\,(\mathrm{Num}_\delta(x, y) \wedge \mathrm{Prf}(y, q))]$, where $\mathrm{Num}_\delta(x, y)$ says that y codes $\delta(\bar{x})$. This is formalized Σ_1-completeness with a free variable. Recursively axiomatized extensions of $I\Sigma_1$ prove it for their canonical provability predicate, and derive the third derivability condition from it [Hájek–Pudlák 1993].

Corollary H (ours)**.** *Under the hypothesis of Theorem J(a), with* Pair *as fixed in §2,* $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ *does not prove* $\forall x\,\exists y\ y = x \cdot x$ *(with multiplication's bounded graph* M*), nor* $\forall x\,\exists y\,\mathrm{Num}(x, y)$*, "every number has a written name". So it does not know uniformly that it watches even the formula* $x = x$*. Under the hypothesis of Theorem J(b), the same holds for* $\mathrm{IS}(A)$*. The deduction method enters only through the truth of Group-3: since the theorems of any sound and complete method are the first-order consequences of the axioms (Fact A), the unprovability holds for every such method once the axioms are true.*

Proof. Every axiom of $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ is a true sentence, bounded or Π_1^*-class. For Groups 0–2 this follows from the hypothesis and Willard's remark that they "can be encoded as Π_1^* sentences" (2005, p. 20); Group-3 is true by Theorem J(a) (Lemma L below). Every axiom of $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ is true by Lemma L(b). Apart from the totality of addition, each is bounded (the Group-0 atoms, 2001, p. 10) or Π_1^--class (Group-1's other axioms, Group-2, and Group-3 by Theorem C.3). So Proposition G applies. The witness $y = x^2$ exceeds $k(x + 1)$ once $x > 2k$. The only y with $\mathrm{Num}(x, y)$ is the code of $\bar{x} = \bar{x}$. In 2005, $\bar{x}$ is a term with at least $\log_2 x$ function symbols (as in Lemma F), one byte each, so by the encoding of §2 the code is at least $32 \cdot 64^{\log_2 x - 1} = x^6/2$. In 2001, $\bar{x}$ is a constant of $\lceil \log_{32}(x+1) \rceil + 1$ bytes (Appendix B, p. 51), and the code is at least $32\,(x + 1)^{6/5}$. Either bound eventually exceeds $k(x + 1)$. The uniform statement for $x = x$ implies $\forall x\,\exists y\,\mathrm{Num}(x, y)$. □

So the faith step fails in Willard's systems in its uniform form, for the plainest reason: they cannot prove that numbers can be written down, because writing a number down costs more than linearly many bits. Each particular number they can name and each particular run they can check; that is watching. The faith step in Oberhoff's proof, step (2), is one closed sentence about the Gödel sentence, though, and there the totality claim is vacuous. If $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is true, no proof s of $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ exists, so "for every s there is a transcript" holds trivially, and Proposition G yields no contradiction. Section 7 proves step (2) unprovable by a different route, and Section 8 shows a bounded transcript statement at work in a theorem of Willard's.

Willard's first statement of the idea continues this essay's epigraph (TR 93-10, p. 7, verbatim):

> This means there will always be adequate memory for writing b_n's binary encoding when there is sufficient memory for storing a semantic tableaux proof of its existence (whereas the same is plainly not true *when multiplication is assumed to be a function*).
>
> For instance, multiplication allows one to establish the existence of a number a_{300} (in a proof with approximately 300 lines), whose binary encoding requires *more digits* than the number of atoms in the universe.

Here $b_{i+1} = b_i + b_i$ and $a_{i+1} = (a_i)^2$. Starting both at 2, $b_n = 2^{n+1}$ and $a_n = 2^{2^n}$: a proof of n doublings names a number of $n+1$ bits, and a proof of n squarings names one of 2^n bits. Willard's later statement compares the Gödel number of a proof with the integer it shows to exist (2006a, Remark 3, p. 24, verbatim):

> In particular, every proof of the existence of an integer N using the additive convention will have a larger Gödel number than N. In contrast, the multiplicative convention allows for the Gödel number of such proofs to have a sharply smaller magnitude than N (when for instance $N = 2^{2^k}$ and k is larger than some fixed constant). In essence, this difference in magnitude is the reason the Second Incompleteness Theorem will generalize under the multiplicative naming paradigm — while Section 4 showed boundary-case exceptions to it exist under the additive naming convention.

5 A Machine That Says "I Am Consistent"

Oberhoff's moral for the second theorem is "if you declare yourself a very stable genius, you're not". Let us build the genius with his tools. Fix a base system $\mathcal{F}_0$, a deduction method D, and a consistency level, and consider

```
C(A) {
  for s ∈ all possible strings {
    if s is a contradiction in F_0 + «A(A) doesn't halt» {
      halt;
    }
  }
}
```

where a *contradiction* is a D-proof of $0 = 1$ (Level(0−)) or a pair of D-proofs of a Π_1-class sentence and of its syntactic negation (Level(1)). (We picked C because it is a circle that never quite closes; §6 explains the joke.) Let

$$\ddot{\mathsf{W}} = \text{«}\mathsf{C}(\mathsf{C}) \text{ doesn't halt»}, \qquad \mathcal{F} = \mathcal{F}_0 + \ddot{\mathsf{W}}.$$

Just as $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ says "I am not provable", $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ says that $\mathcal{F}$ is consistent at the chosen level. So $\mathcal{F}$ proves its own consistency in one line: the claim is an axiom.

C is not an analogy. It is Willard's construction read as a program. In 2005 (pp. 9–10), $ExPrf^{D}_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(h,t,p)$ says that p is a D-proof of t from Groups 0–2 plus the sentence coded h, and $SubstPrf^{D}_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(g,t,p)$, his Eq. (7), combines it with $\mathrm{SUBST}(g,h)$: the input A is g, and «$\mathsf{A}(\mathsf{A})$ doesn't halt» is the sentence h with $\mathrm{SUBST}(g,h)$. His Group-3 axiom, Eq. (8), is $\Gamma_3(\bar{n}_3)$, where n_3 is the Gödel number of

$$\Gamma_3(g) := \forall x\, \forall y\, \forall p\, \forall q\, \neg[\mathrm{Pair}(x,y) \wedge SubstPrf^{D}_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(g,x,p) \wedge SubstPrf^{D}_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(g,y,q)]$$

(Willard writes Γ and n; we add the subscript to keep it apart from the Gödel sentence's Γ and n of §2). This is «$\mathsf{C}(\mathsf{C})$ doesn't halt» at Level(1); 2001's Appendix B does the same at Level(0−). Willard (2016, Definition 3.4 and Example 3.5) remarks that constructing such a sentence is "relatively easy, via an application of the Fixed Point Theorem, but this sentence is ironically typically useless!"

Proposition I (The genius falls; standard)**.** *Let $\mathcal{F}_0$ be a recursively axiomatized extension of $I\Sigma_1$ in the language of arithmetic, D Hilbert-style deduction,* Prov *the canonical Σ_1 provability predicate, and $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ as above at either level. Then $\mathcal{F} = \mathcal{F}_0 + \ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ is inconsistent, and $\mathsf{C}(\mathsf{C})$ halts.*

Proof. Suppose $\mathcal{F}$ is consistent.

$\Rightarrow$ $\mathcal{F}$ proves its own consistency: $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ is one of its axioms, and by the diagonal lemma $I\Sigma_1$ proves $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ equivalent to the consistency statement of $\mathcal{F}_0 + \ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ at the chosen level, for the canonical proof predicate. $I\Sigma_1$ also proves the two levels equivalent for $\mathcal{F}$: it proves explosion for the canonical Hilbert proof predicate, so a proof of $0 = 1$ yields proofs of every sentence, and it proves that proofs of a sentence and of its negation combine, by modus ponens, into a proof of $0 = 1$.

$\Rightarrow$ $\mathcal{F}$ is a recursively axiomatized extension of $I\Sigma_1$, so the derivability conditions hold for its canonical provability predicate, provably in $I\Sigma_1$ [Hájek–Pudlák 1993]. In Oberhoff's terms, $\mathcal{F}$ knows that it watches, and steps (1)–(3) are theorems of $\mathcal{F}$.

$\Rightarrow$ So by the second incompleteness theorem (Oberhoff's Theorem 6, with its faith step now a theorem), $\mathcal{F}$ cannot prove its own consistency. $\lightning$

So $\mathcal{F}$ is inconsistent. A contradiction from $\mathcal{F}$ is then a finite object that exists, and $\mathsf{C}(\mathsf{C})$ finds it. □

Willard records that "Kleene, Rogers and Jeroslow [...] each warned their readers that most axiom systems, similar to α^*, were useless on account of their inconsistency, although they were technically well-defined" (2005, §1). Two of his own theorems are instances in his own languages. $\mathrm{XIS}^{\lambda}(\mathrm{PAX})$, his tableau system with multiplication total and a reflection-style Group-3 axiom, "is inconsistent" for every λ (2001, Theorem 7.3, p. 40, `full`). And Section 8 describes the finest instance, where the system falls because of one added axiom saying that one number exists.

6 Willard's Machine

Willard keeps C and $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ and changes $\mathcal{F}_0$ and D. We describe the 2005 system $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ and note where the 2001 system $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ differs.

The system $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ (2005, §3, pp. 8–10). A is any axiom system in the U-Grounding language whose proof predicate Prf_A is Δ_0^*, and D is a deduction method.

- **Group-0** (names): four axioms fixing $\bar{c}_0$, $\bar{c}_1$, $+$ and *Double*, so that every $n \geq 2$ has the name $\overline{n}$ of $O(\log n)$ symbols.
- **Group-1** (watching): a finite set of true Π_1^* sentences which, with Group-0, proves every Δ_0^* sentence true in the standard model. Willard's Table I (2001, pp. 63–64) is one such set.
- **Group-2** (inheritance): for each Π_1^* sentence Φ, the axiom $\forall p\,\{\mathrm{Prf}_A(\ulcorner\Phi\urcorner, p) \rightarrow \Phi\}$ (2005, Eq. 5). The schema is indexed by all Π_1^* sentences, not by A's theorems; for Φ that A does not prove, the axiom is vacuously true.
- **Group-3** (self-reference): the single Π_1^* sentence $\Gamma_3(\bar{n}_3)$ of §5, Level(1) consistency of $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ under D, with $\mathrm{Prf}^D_{\mathrm{IS}_D(A)}(t,p)$ encoded as $\mathit{SubstPrf}^D_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(\bar{n}_3, t, p)$ (p. 10). Willard stresses that the Π_1^* form is essential (2005, p. 10).

The deduction methods are *semantic tableaux* (2005, §2, pp. 6–7: a tree rooted at $\neg\Phi$ in prenex form, with elimination rules only and no cut, every branch closed by some Υ and $\neg\Upsilon$) and Tab$-U_1^*-$List: a list of tableau proofs, each of which may use the earlier conclusions as axioms, all intermediate

conclusions being Π_1^* or Σ_1^* (2005, p. 7). The latter is a restricted modus ponens: lemmas are allowed, provided each has at most one unbounded quantifier block.

IS(A) of 2001 differs in three respects: its language is the 2001 grounding language, with a constant for every number and addition total by an axiom rather than a function symbol; D is semantic tableaux; and its Group-3 axiom asserts Level(0−) consistency, $\forall y \neg SemPrf_{\mathrm{IS}(A)}(\ulcorner 0 = 1 \urcorner, y)$ (2001, Eq. 8), with a Π_1^- encoding (2001, Theorem C.3, p. 60). Willard assumes throughout that A extends Peano Arithmetic (2001, p. 9).

Theorem J (Willard)**.**

(a) (2005, Theorems 3 and 5, pp. 27, 29, ***full****.) If every* Π_1^* *theorem of* A *is true in the standard model, then* $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ *is consistent, both for* $D =$ *semantic tableaux and for* $D = \mathrm{Tab}{-}U_1^*{-}\mathrm{List}$*. The proof (via Theorem 1) rules out* D*-proofs of a* Π_1^* *sentence* Φ *and of "the* Σ_1^* *theorem that is* Φ*'s negation" (p. 20),* $\mathrm{dual}(\Phi)$*. With* Pair *as fixed in §2, a proof of any* θ *with* $\mathrm{Pair}(\ulcorner \Phi \urcorner, \ulcorner \theta \urcorner)$ *is a proof of* $\mathrm{dual}(\Phi)$*, so Group-3 is true: Level(1) consistency.*

(b) (2001, Theorem 4.3, p. 20, ***full****.) If* A *is* regularly consistent*, meaning that* Prf_A *has a* Δ_0^- *encoding and every Group-2 axiom of* $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ *is true (2001, p. 12), then* $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ *is consistent: there is no tableau proof of* $0 = 1$*, which is Level(0−).*

Both are relative consistency theorems in the sense of §2. Willard also states that IS's construction fails for Hilbert deduction: by Pudlák and Solovay, "if D denotes Hilbert deduction then our $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ system will be automatically inconsistent" (2005, p. 8, text layer).

Lemma K (ours)**.** *For* $D =$ *semantic tableaux or* $\mathrm{Tab}{-}U_1^*{-}\mathrm{List}$*,* $(\mathrm{IS}_D(A), D)$ *watches.*

Proof. Let $\sigma = \exists \vec{x}\, \delta(\vec{x})$ be a true Σ_1^* sentence with witnesses $\vec{k}$. Then $\delta(\overline{\vec{k}})$ is a true Δ_0^* sentence, which Groups 0 and 1 prove, and σ is its logical consequence. Apply Fact A. □

The same holds for $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ with $A \supseteq \mathrm{PAX}$: a system that verifies the Π_1^- theorems of PAX "obviously has a capacity to prove every Δ_0^- sentence which is true" (2001, p. 39, text layer), and $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ names every number by a constant. So a true Σ_1^- sentence $\exists \vec{x}\, \delta(\vec{x})$, with witnesses $\vec{k}$, has the true Δ_0^- instance $\delta(\overline{\vec{k}})$, which $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ proves, and Fact A adds the existential quantifiers, as in Lemma K. For general programs, Willard notes that the predicate $Turing(x, y, z)$ is expressible in $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ (TR 93-10, p. 6), so halting of any program is a Σ_1^- sentence there; the arguments below need only the proof-searchers, whose halting is formalized through Prf directly.

Lemma L (ours)**.**

(a) If every Π_1^* *theorem of* A *is true, then every theorem of* $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ *is true in the standard model, and its proof predicate* $SubstPrf^D_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(\bar{n}_3, \cdot, \cdot)$ *is correct there.*

(b) If A *is regularly consistent, then every theorem of* $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ *is true in the standard model.*

Proof. (a) *Correctness.* By Willard's arithmetization (§2), SUBST, $\mathrm{Prf}^D_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}$ and $ExPrf^D_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}$ are correct bounded definitions. A D-proof p from $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ either uses Group-3 or not. If not, it satisfies the first disjunct of Eq. (7). If it does, Group-3 occurs in it as a node, so by the encoding of §2 Group-3's code h_3 satisfies $h_3 \leq p$, and the second disjunct holds with $h = h_3$. Conversely each disjunct describes a D-proof from $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$, given that $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}_3, h)$ holds only for $h = h_3$.

Truth. Groups 0 and 1 are true (Willard: "It is obvious that all $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$'s Group-0 and 1 axioms are valid under the standard model", 2005, p. 20, text layer). Group-2 is true by hypothesis. Group-3 is true by Theorem J(a), as noted there. Theorems of true axioms under a sound D are true.

(b) *Correctness.* IS(A)'s Group-3 axiom is $\Theta(\bar{N})$, with $\Theta(g) := \forall y \neg \mathit{SubstSemPrf}_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(\ulcorner 0 = 1 \urcorner, y, g)$, where $\mathit{SubstSemPrf}_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(s, y, g)$ says that y is a tableau proof of s from UNION(A) together with the sentence h such that SUBST(g, h) (2001, Eqs. 86–87, p. 52). Its Δ_0^- definition is Willard's: item 25 of Theorem C.1 and Theorem C.2 (both `sketch`). His test examines each node s of y for being the Group-3 axiom, searching for h with SUBST(g, h) under the bound $h \leq s$: "We may assume that our encoding scheme is designed so that $h \leq s$ when h exists" (Appendix C, item 24 and p. 59, text layer). In 2001's encoding each tableau node opens with a curly bracket followed by its sentence (Appendix B, p. 52). So a node's byte string is a contiguous part of y, $s \leq y$, and the bounds cover every proof that uses the axiom, by the node argument of (a). Hence the formula holds in the standard model exactly of the tableau proofs from IS(A), and the proof predicate $\mathit{SubstSemPrf}_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(\cdot, \cdot, \bar{N})$ of IS(A) is correct.

Truth. Group-0 consists of true atomic facts about the constants (2001, p. 10). Group-1 is true. Group-2 is true by regular consistency (2001, p. 12). Group-3, which by correctness says that no tableau proof of $0 = 1$ from IS(A) exists, is true by Theorem J(b). Tableaux are sound. □

So $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ and IS(A) are honest in Oberhoff's sense, under the hypotheses of Lemma L. If in addition A proves the Π_1^* theorems of PA+ (Peano Arithmetic with the U-Grounding function symbols, 2005, p. 32), $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ obeys the first incompleteness theorem. By Oberhoff's §4 argument, spelled out as Proposition M(b) and Corollary N(a) below, $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is unprovable; $\neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ and H are false, hence unprovable by honesty. Rosser's version also goes through. The same holds for IS(A) with $A \supseteq$ PAX regularly consistent: the proof of Proposition M(b) needs only Level(0−) consistency, watching and SUBST($\bar{n}, \bar{c}$) (Corollary O below), and honesty is Lemma L(b). In both cases the finite search that Oberhoff writes out is a true bounded fact, which Groups 0 and 1 prove. In case 2, $\mathsf{B}(\mathsf{B})$ enters its loop at a definite step, and PA+ proves the Π_1^* sentence $\Phi =$ «$\mathsf{B}(\mathsf{B})$ doesn't halt». Group-2 hands it to $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ by detachment: A proves Φ with some proof p, Groups 0 and 1 prove the true Δ_0^* sentence $\mathrm{Prf}_A(\ulcorner \Phi \urcorner, \bar{p})$, and with Φ's Group-2 axiom Fact A gives Φ. For IS(A) the loop sentence is the corresponding Π_1^- sentence of the 2001 language, which PAX proves; the Group-2 axiom of 2001, Eq. (7) (p. 10), hands it over by the same detachment. Willard said so in his first technical report: IS(A) is "a class of structures, lying halfway between Peano Arithmetic and Presburger Arithmetic, which satisfy Godel's First but not Second Incompleteness Theorem" (TR 93-10, p. 6, verbatim).

Why it is consistent, in Oberhoff's format. Willard's 2005 proof needs two definitions. A Π_1^* sentence $\forall \vec{x}\, \psi$ is *App*$\forall(a)$*-valid* if ψ holds for all $\vec{x} \leq a$; a Σ_1^* sentence $\exists \vec{x}\, \psi$ is *App*$\exists(b)$*-valid* if it has a witness $\vec{x} \leq b$ (Eqs. 16–17; bounded quantifiers are left alone). For $a > b \geq 1$, α is *Normed*(a, b) if every axiom is a Π_1^* sentence with App$\forall(a)$ validity or a Σ_1^* sentence with App$\exists(b)$ validity, in the U-Grounding language with no other function symbol (Definition 4, p. 19). D is *θ-compactified*, for a constant $0 < \theta < 1/3$, if whenever $p \leq \lceil a/b \rceil + 1$ is a D-proof of Φ from a Normed(a, b) system, a Σ_1^* Φ is App$\exists(b \cdot p^\theta)$-valid and a Π_1^* Φ is App$\forall(a/p^\theta)$-valid (Definition 5, p. 19). In words: a proof p can push an existential witness out by at most a factor p^θ, and can shrink a universal's certified range by at most the same factor. Tableaux are $\frac{1}{4}$-compactified (Theorem 2, p. 26, `full`), and so are tableau lists (Theorem 4, p. 28, `full`). Here is Theorem 1 (p. 19, `full`), with $\theta = \frac{1}{4}$:

Suppose $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ is inconsistent:

⇒ Then $\mathsf{C}(\mathsf{C})$ halts: there are D-proofs j_1 of a Π_1^* sentence Φ and j_2 of a sentence θ with Pair$(\ulcorner \Phi \urcorner, \ulcorner \theta \urcorner)$. By §2, j_2 is also a proof of $\Psi :=$ dual(Φ), "the Σ_1^* theorem that is Φ's negation" (p. 20). Choose the pair with $m = \max(j_1, j_2)$ as small as possible.

⇒ Groups 0–2 are true. Group-3 is false, but its first counterexample is a pair of proofs whose maximum is m, so it is App$\forall(m-1)$-valid. Hence $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ is Normed$(m-1,1)$, which presupposes $m-1>1$; under Willard's encoding every proof has Gödel number far above 3.

⇒ The proof $j_1 \le m$ certifies the universal Φ out to $(m-1)/m^{1/4}$. The proof $j_2 \le m$ finds a witness for the existential Ψ at most $m^{1/4}$.

⇒ Since $(m-1)/m^{1/4} > m^{1/4}$, the witness for Ψ lies where Φ has been certified. ↯

The work is in the third arrow, θ-compactification, and it is a program. For Part A of Theorem 2 (p. 26), suppose a tableau p proves a Σ_1^* sentence Φ from a Normed(a,b) system but Φ has no witness $\le b\,p^{1/4}$:

Suppose p is a tableau proof of Φ and Φ is not App$\exists(b\,p^{1/4})$-valid:

⇒ Then the root $\neg\Phi$ is App$\forall(b\,p^{1/4})$-valid, and the axioms together with the root form a Normed$(b\,p^{1/4}, b)$ system.

⇒ Run *Probe* (Lemma 1, p. 23, `full`): walk down p from the root; at a fork take a child that still satisfies the branch condition (each universal valid up to $b\,p^{1/4}$, each existential witnessed below b, each bounded sentence true) under the current valuation; when an existential is eliminated, give its new parameter the least value that keeps the branch true. Every parameter introduced at a node of U-Depth Δ gets a value at most $b\cdot 2^{\Delta}$ (Eq. 19), because terms grow at most by doubling.

⇒ The walk succeeds if the tree's U-Height is below $\log_2(b\,p^{1/4}) - \log_2 b = \frac{1}{4}\log_2 p$, which Eq. (20) guarantees.

⇒ A branch found by *Probe* cannot close (Lemma 2, p. 25, `full`): a closing pair must be bounded sentences (footnote 3), and both would be true under the valuation.

⇒ So p has an open branch, and is not a proof. ↯

Part B, for Π_1^* sentences, permutes the quantifiers (Appendix B, pp. 40–41). Theorem 3, for tableaux, is then immediate, and Theorem 5, for tableau lists, follows the same way from Theorem 4.

Why Pair *is fixed as it is.* Theorem 1 is about a Π_1^* sentence and its Σ_1^* negation, because App$\exists$ validity is defined for Σ_1^* sentences (Definition 5). Willard's Eq. (28), though, pairs f with the string $\neg f$. With an unspecified Prenex* rewriting, a proof of $\neg\Phi$ need not be a proof of dual(Φ), and Willard's "If $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ is inconsistent, then such a triple (j_1, j_2, m) will clearly exist" (p. 20, text layer) would pass over that step. The convention and the Pair of §2 close it: every sentence Pair accepts has exactly the tableau proofs of dual(Φ).

Willard's earlier intuition for the 2001 system, his "Assertion ++", is the same horizon argument seen from the other side (2001, Remark 4.4, p. 20, verbatim): "any proof y of $0=1$ from IS(A) will be automatically associated with an ordered pair (p,u) where $p \le \mathrm{VALUE}(u) < y$ and p represents ANOTHER proof of $0=1$". He calls this a *vacuous truth*, an implication whose hypothesis is never satisfied. The 2001 proof replaces it by an eleven-case induction showing that the least tableau proof y of $0=1$ contains a branch on which every sentence is true once its unbounded quantifiers are cut off at $y-1$ (Lemma 4.8, p. 23, `full`), which cannot close (Lemma 4.6, p. 22, `full`). The Group-3 axiom is false, but its cut-off at $y-1$ is true, because y is the least refutation. The naming bounds are Lemma 4.1 (a constant mentioned in y has value below $\sqrt{y}$, p. 17, `full`) and Lemma 4.2 (along such a branch every parameter has value below y, p. 19, `sketch`), whose intuition is that fewer than $\frac{1}{3}\log_2 y$ doublings take values at most to $y^{1/2}\cdot y^{1/3} = y^{5/6} < y$ (the product is our unpacking of the sketch). The formal proof uses a different majorant, Part II of the affirmative-branch definition,

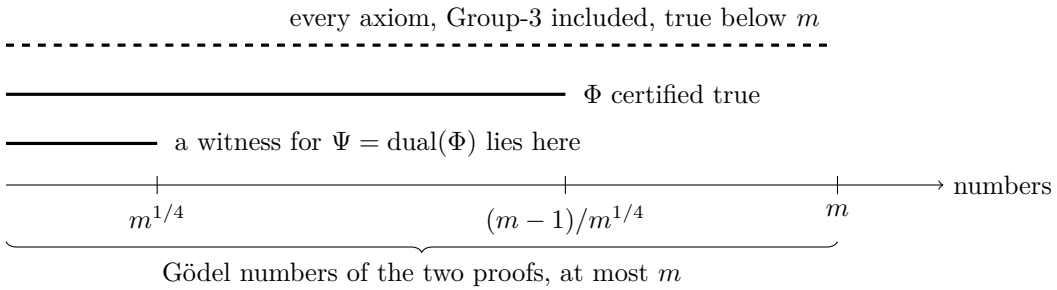


Figure 1: The two horizons in the proof of Willard's 2005 Theorem 1 (schematic, not to scale). A universal theorem is certified out to its horizon, an existential one finds its witness inside its horizon, and when horizons are short compared with the proofs, the two collide in the region where every axiom is true.

$\mathrm{VALUE}(u) < (k + \sqrt{y}) \cdot 2^{\lfloor \beta_i/6 \rfloor - 2}$ (Eq. 26, p. 22), where β_i is the bit-length of the first i levels of the branch and each doubling is paid for by the six bits of Case 11. Willard later found this proof "hard to visualize" and replaced it by Theorem 1 (2005, Remark 2, p. 21).

Three remarks.

The proof is a program. Probe takes any purported proof and returns an open branch together with values for its parameters. Willard's consistency proof is therefore a machine that defeats each refutation by running it, in a universe barely larger than the refutation itself. That is self-justification ex machina in the most literal sense. (And it is why we named the searcher C: it hunts for a tree all of whose branches close, and the walk always finds one that stays open.) $\mathcal{F}$ does not prove that the machine works; that is the external part. $\mathcal{F}$ has only the axiom.

The encoding enters as a floor. The horizon is measured in Gödel numbers, so the argument needs every symbol to cost bits: Eq. (20) requires on average more than five bits per U-Grounding function symbol along the deepest branch, and 2001's Case 11 needs the sentence introducing a sum to require "substantially more than six bits" (2001, p. 28). Larger Gödel numbers only widen the margin, and Willard says so: "All our theorems would also be valid for uncompressed encoding methods. However, they are more meaningful when one uses an efficiently compressed B-adic encoding method" (2005, p. 40, text layer). 2006a makes the analogous remark for the Hilbert line: its theorems "have analogs under such uncompressed encoding methods, but they are substantially more meaningful" when compressed (Appendix A, p. 37, text layer). What would break the 2005 proof of Theorem 2 is a notation *more* compact than its argument allows. Part A needs $\text{U-Height}(p) < \frac{1}{4} \log_2 p$ (footnote 5, p. 27), so the third arrow fails once there are on average four or fewer bits per U-Grounding function symbol along the deepest branch. Whether Theorem 3 itself fails for such an encoding Willard does not say, and we do not know.

The closing inequality. Willard closes the proof of Theorem 1 with "since $\theta < \frac{1}{3}$ implies $g > h$", where $g = (m-1)/m^{\theta}$ and $h = m^{\theta}$ (p. 20). That needs $m - 1 > m^{2\theta}$, which holds for every $\theta < \frac{1}{3}$ once $m \geq 4$, and for $\theta = \frac{1}{4}$ once $m \geq 3$. Under Appendix A's encoding every proof has Gödel number above $32 \cdot 64^2$, so the gap is harmless; Theorems 3 and 5, which are corollaries of Theorem 1, inherit both the gap and its repair.

7 The Faith Is Not Just Missing

One might think Willard's systems are self-justifying merely because nobody has managed to prove step (2) in them. In fact they cannot prove it, and the reason is Oberhoff's Theorem 6 run

backwards.

Proposition M (ours)**.** *Let* $(\mathcal{F}, D)$ *be a configuration with* D $\mathcal{F}$*-sound and* $\mathcal{F}$*-complete, and* $\mathrm{Prf}_{\mathcal{F}}^{D}$ *a bounded formula that is correct in the standard model (it holds of* (h, x) *exactly when* x *codes a* D*-proof from* $\mathcal{F}$ *of the sentence coded* h*), with* SUBST *likewise correct. Let* $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$*,* H*,* c *and* c' *be as in §2. Suppose:*

(H1) $\mathcal{F}$ *is Level(0−) consistent: there is no* D*-proof of* $0 = 1$ *from* $\mathcal{F}$*;*

(H2) $(\mathcal{F}, D)$ *watches;*

(H3) $\mathcal{F}$ *proves the true bounded sentences and trichotomy at* $\bar{c}$*, so that (FP) holds (Fact B);*

(H4) $\mathcal{F}$ *proves its own Level(1) consistency,* $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \forall x\, \forall y\, \forall p\, \forall q\, \neg[\mathrm{Pair}(x, y) \wedge \mathrm{Prf}_{\mathcal{F}}^{D}(x, p) \wedge \mathrm{Prf}_{\mathcal{F}}^{D}(y, q)]$*, for a bounded* Pair *with* $\mathrm{Pair}(\bar{c}, \bar{c}\,')$ *true.*

Then:

(a) $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D (2) \leftrightarrow \ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ *and* $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D [\mathsf{H} \supset \mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}\,')] \leftrightarrow \ddot{\mathsf{G}}$*;*

(b) $\mathcal{F} \nvdash_D \ddot{\mathsf{G}}$*;*

(c) hence $\mathcal{F}$ *proves neither step (2) nor the instance of knowing that it watches at the* Σ_1*-class sentence* H*, and both are true.*

Part (b) uses only (H1), (H2), $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \bar{c})$*, the correctness of* $\mathrm{Prf}_{\mathcal{F}}^{D}$*, and the soundness and completeness of* D*.*

Proof. (a) By (H3), $\mathcal{F}$ proves the true bounded sentence $\mathrm{Pair}(\bar{c}, \bar{c}\,')$. With (H4), Fact A gives step (3): $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \neg[\mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}) \wedge \mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}\,')]$. Now take the two directions. Step (3) and (FP) together imply (2) $\supset \ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ in every model: from (2) and (3), $\neg\mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c})$, and then (FP) gives $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$. (FP) alone implies $\ddot{\mathsf{G}} \supset$ (2) in every model: $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ gives $\neg\mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c})$, which makes the antecedent of (2) false. Since $\mathcal{F}$ proves (3) and (FP), Fact A, applied with these two implications as its conclusion χ, gives $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D (2) \leftrightarrow \ddot{\mathsf{G}}$. The second equivalence follows by Lemma E(b).

(b) This is Oberhoff's §4, case 1:

⇒ Suppose $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \ddot{\mathsf{G}}$, by a proof m.

⇒ Since $\mathrm{Prf}_{\mathcal{F}}^{D}$ is correct, $\mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c})$ is a true Σ_1-class sentence (with witness m), so $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c})$ by (H2): $\mathcal{F}$ watches $\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halt.

⇒ By (FP⇒) and Fact A, $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D \neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$. Then $\mathcal{F}$ proves both $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ and $\neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$, and Fact A gives $\mathcal{F} \vdash_D 0 = 1$, against (H1). ↯

(c) By (a) and (b). Truth: since no proof of $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ exists and $\mathrm{Prf}_{\mathcal{F}}^{D}$ and SUBST are correct, $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is true in the standard model, step (2) is true because its antecedent is false, and the instance is true because H is false. □

In a system that meets these hypotheses, then, the faith step *is* the Gödel sentence, up to provable equivalence, and is true and unprovable for the same reason. It fails at a Σ_1-class sentence that says $\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halts, and at every sentence with the same tableau proofs, $\neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ among them, since Pair accepts those too. A Σ_1 formalization of the halting statement with *different* tableau proofs, such as $\exists x\, \exists h\, [\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, h) \wedge \mathrm{Prf}(h, x)]$, is a different sentence, because Prov is sensitive to codes. The proposition says nothing about it, and the essay's claims do not need it.

Corollary N (ours)**.** *Let A prove every Π_1^* theorem of* PA+*, let every Π_1^* theorem of A be true, and let D be semantic tableaux or* Tab$-U_1^*-$List*. Take $\mathrm{Prf}^D_{\mathrm{IS}_D(A)}$ to be Willard's SubstPrf$^D_{\mathrm{UNION}(A)}(\bar{n}_3,\cdot,\cdot)$, with* Pair*, the Prenex* convention and the encoding as fixed in §2, and $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ and H built from it. Then:*

(a) $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ *does not prove* $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$*;*

(b) $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ *proves neither step (2) nor the instance of knowing that it watches at* H*.*

Proof. The proof predicate. Willard's Eq. (7) is Δ_0^* (2005, p. 10), so $\mathrm{Prf}^D_{\mathrm{IS}_D(A)}$ is bounded, and it is correct by Lemma L(a).

Group-2 detachment. If A proves a Π_1^* sentence Φ by a proof p, then Groups 0 and 1 prove the true Δ_0^* sentence $\mathrm{Prf}_A(\ulcorner\Phi\urcorner,\bar{p})$, and with Φ's Group-2 axiom $\forall p\,\{\mathrm{Prf}_A(\ulcorner\Phi\urcorner,p)\to\Phi\}$ (Eq. 5), Fact A gives $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)\vdash_D\Phi$.

The hypotheses. (H1): by Theorem J(a), Group-3 is true, so no Π_1^* sentence and its Σ_1^* negation both have proofs; a D-proof of $0=1$ would, by Fact A, yield proofs of every sentence, including such a pair. (H2) is Lemma K. (H3): Groups 0 and 1 prove the true bounded sentences, $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n},\bar{c})$ and $\mathrm{Pair}(\bar{c},\bar{c}\,')$ among them. Trichotomy is a Π_1 theorem of Peano Arithmetic, and so a Π_1^* theorem of PA+, which detachment hands to $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$. (H4) is literally the Group-3 axiom, Eq. (8). Part (a) is Proposition M(b), part (b) is Proposition M(c). □

Nothing in this corollary is assumed beyond what is cited: Willard's consistency theorem and arithmetization, with their stated statuses, and the conventions fixed in §2. $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ is never asked to prove that its Group-3 formula is its own proof predicate; that correctness is used in the metatheory only.

Corollary O (ours)**.** *Let $A\supseteq$ PAX be regularly consistent and D semantic tableaux, and let $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ and H be built from the proof predicate of* IS(A)*'s Group-3 axiom, with the conventions of §2. Then* IS(A) *does not prove $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$, and does not prove both step (2) and the Level(0−) form of step (3),* $\forall p\,\forall q\,[\mathrm{Prf}(\bar{c},p)\wedge\mathrm{Prf}(\bar{c}\,',q)\supset\exists r\,\mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner 0=1\urcorner,r)]$.

Proof. The hypotheses of Proposition M other than (H4) hold in the setting of Willard's own Theorem 7.2. (H1) is Theorem J(b). (H2): IS(A) proves every true Δ_0^- sentence (2001, p. 39) and names every number by a constant, so for a true Σ_1^- sentence it proves the true Δ_0^- instance at the witnesses, and Fact A adds the existential quantifiers. (H3): IS(A) proves the true Δ_0^- sentences, among them $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n},\bar{c})$ (2001, p. 39), and trichotomy is a Π_1^- theorem of PAX, inherited through Group-2. The proof predicate is correct by Lemma L(b). So Proposition M(b) gives $\mathrm{IS}(A)\nvdash\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$. If IS($A$) proved both step (2) and the combination sentence, then with its Group-3 axiom $\forall r\,\neg\mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner 0=1\urcorner,r)$ it would prove step (3), $\neg[\mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c})\wedge\mathrm{Prov}(\bar{c}\,')]$, which is all the proof of Proposition M(a) uses of (H4). That proof would then give $\mathrm{IS}(A)\vdash\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$. ↯ □

So for the 2001 system the closed faith step fails in at least one of two places, and we do not know which. Its uniform form fails outright (Corollary H).

The proposition is a contrapositive and claims no novelty of method. Its sibling in Willard is 2001 Theorem 7.2 (p. 38, `full`): no consistent α with a Δ_0^- proof predicate, an α-sound and α-complete D, and all Π_1^- theorems of PAX can prove the canonical reflection principle $\forall y\,\{\mathrm{Prf}^D_\alpha(\ulcorner\Upsilon\urcorner,y)\supset\Upsilon\}$ for every Π_1^- sentence Υ. Its proof uses the same fixed point and the same Fact A in place of the derivability conditions; "The above result is different from Löb's Theorem … chiefly because we do not assume that α recognizes either Addition or Multiplication as total functions" (p. 38, text layer). Willard's 1994 framing already sets out the alternatives: "every axiom system either fails to prove its consistency or fails to meet the full Hilbert-Bernays conditions" (TR 93-10, p. 6, verbatim).

What the computational reading adds is *which* condition fails, at *which* sentence, and that the failing instance is the Gödel sentence in disguise. What Willard adds, and no contrapositive can supply, is that systems on the far side of the alternative *exist* (Theorem J).

8 The Faith, Bought: Willard's Theorem 6

Willard's 2005 paper ends by doing the experiment. Take the transcript statement of §4, bound it, and see what it costs to switch it on.

Let Log^k be the k-fold base-2 logarithm, rounded down, and $\Upsilon(k,m)$ the true Σ_1^* sentence $\exists z\, \mathrm{Log}^k(z) \geq \bar{m}$, which says that a number at least 2_k^m exists, where 2_k^m, the least z with $\mathrm{Log}^k(z) \geq m$, is roughly a tower of k exponentials topped by m (2005, Definition 2, p. 11). $\mathrm{NS}_D^{k,m}(A)$ is $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ with $\Upsilon(k,m)$ added to Group-0 and Group-3's "this" adjusted to the larger system (Definition 3, p. 11). Both systems prove $\Upsilon(k,m)$; only one of them has it as an axiom. Let $\mho(s,b)$ be the bounded Gödel sentence "no proof p of me with $\mathrm{Log}^s(p) < b$" (Eq. 24, p. 33), and *CheckProof*(t,p,q) the Δ_0^* formula "p proves t, and q proves $\exists p\, \mathrm{Prf}(t,p)$" (Definition 6, p. 33). Lemma 4 (p. 33, `full`, resting on Lemma 3, a proof `sketch` that checking a proof is quasi-polynomially cheap) says that for k large Peano Arithmetic proves the Π_1^* sentence (Willard writes Peano Arithmetic; the sentence is in the U-Grounding language, so the theory meant is PA+)

$$\forall p \forall n \exists q < n \{[\mathrm{Log}^{k-1} p < m \wedge \mathrm{Log}^k n \geq m \wedge \mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner \mho(k-1,m) \urcorner, p)] \\ \rightarrow \mathit{CheckProof}(\ulcorner \mho(k-1,m) \urcorner, p, q)\}. \quad (27)$$

This is the literal transcript of step (2), bounded. For every short proof p of the Gödel sentence and every number n that is big enough, a transcript q exists below n, and q proves the Σ_1^* sentence (25), $\exists p\, \mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner \mho(k-1,m) \urcorner, p)$: "$\mho$ is provable". Unlike the halting sentence for $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$, this is not equivalent to the negation of the Gödel sentence. $\mho$ speaks only of short proofs, so $\neg\mho$ says that a short proof exists, while (25) says that some proof exists. Because the transcript is bounded by n, the statement is Π_1^*, and the system inherits it from PA+ through Group-2. What is missing is n. (Willard states Lemma 4 for the proof predicate of $\mathrm{NS}_D^{k,m}(\mathrm{PA}+)$. Lemma 3's sketch is generic in the axiom system: the cited literature treats "an axiom system α", and "an analogous construction" is to apply it to NS (p. 33). Applied to $\mathrm{IS}_D(\mathrm{PA}+)$, the same construction gives the bounded transcript statement for that system's own proof predicate, with the same status, `sketch`. Willard does not state it.)

Theorem P (Willard 2005, Theorem 6, p. 34; `full` as printed, a `sketch` at this granularity, as explained below)**.** *For* $D = \mathrm{Tab}{-}U_1^*{-}\mathrm{List}$ *there is* k_0 *such that for every* $k > k_0$, $\mathrm{NS}_D^{k,m}(\mathrm{PA}+)$ *is inconsistent.*

Willard's proof is a seven-step tableau list W (pp. 34–36), and, with its fourth step repaired as sketched below, it is Oberhoff's Theorem 6 with the faith supplied:

- $\Rightarrow$ (27), inherited from Peano Arithmetic: the faith step, below n.
- $\Rightarrow$ (28) $\mathrm{Pair}(\ulcorner \mho \urcorner, \ulcorner \neg \mho \urcorner)$, a true bounded sentence; with Pair as fixed in §2, also $\mathrm{Pair}(\ulcorner \mho \urcorner, \ulcorner \mathrm{dual}(\mho) \urcorner)$.
- $\Rightarrow$ (29) the Group-3 axiom, and (30) its instance: step (3).
- $\Rightarrow$ (31), a step Willard calls "mostly notational": no p, q satisfy *CheckProof*$(\ulcorner \mho \urcorner, p, q)$. Then (32), chaining with (27): no short proof of $\mho$ coexists with a big n.
- $\Rightarrow$ (33) $\Upsilon(k,m)$, an axiom, supplies n: no short proof of $\mho$ exists. This is $\mho(k-1,m)$ itself, which the seventh step derives.

⇒ Because $\Upsilon(k,m)$ cost nothing, W is short: for $k > k_0$ its Gödel number is below 2^m_{k-1}, so W is itself one of the short proofs that $\mho(k-1,m)$ says do not exist. The system watches W and refutes $\mho$. ↯

Willard's fourth step meets the distinction drawn after Proposition M. He derives (31) from (30) on the ground that "the definitions of CheckProof and $\mho(k-1,m)$ imply that CheckProof($\ulcorner\mho\urcorner, p, q$) is logically equivalent to Equation (30)'s curly bracket expression" (p. 35, text layer), that is, to $\mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner\mho\urcorner, p) \wedge \mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner\neg\mho\urcorner, q)$. By Definition 6, as printed (we checked the page image), q proves (25), which is no sentence that Pair pairs with $\mho$. (25) has neither the substitution nor the bound $\mathrm{Log}^{k-1}(p) < m$, and a long proof of $\mho$ makes (25) true and $\neg\mho$ false. No reading of Willard's text removes this, so the step needs a repair.

The repair (ours, a sketch). Replace (28) by the true bounded sentence $\mathrm{Pair}(\ulcorner\mho\urcorner, \ulcorner\mathrm{dual}(\mho)\urcorner)$, which Pair as fixed in §2 accepts. With (29) it gives $\forall p \forall q \neg[\mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner\mho\urcorner, p) \wedge \mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner\mathrm{dual}(\mho)\urcorner, q)]$ in place of (30). Then redefine *CheckProof*(t,p,q) so that q proves $\mathrm{dual}(\mho)$. Now (31) follows from the new (30) by pure logic, since *CheckProof* is literally its bracket. What remains is to show that such a q is short. Given a proof p of $\mho = \mho(k-1,m)$ with $\mathrm{Log}^{k-1}(p) < m$, a q can be built as a tableau list of four parts:

(i) a proof of the bounded sentence $\mathrm{Prf}(\ulcorner\mho\urcorner, \bar{p})$, which is the object Lemma 3's sketch constructs: "q is a proof that p is a M-encoded proof" (p. 33);

(ii) a proof of the bounded sentence $\mathrm{Log}^{k-1}(\bar{p}) < \bar{m}$, which evaluates a closed term built from the non-growth function *Logarithm*;

(iii) a proof of the true bounded sentence $\mathrm{SUBST}(\bar{n}, \ulcorner\mho\urcorner)$, which depends only on k and m;

(iv) a tableau whose root, $\mathrm{dual}(\mathrm{dual}(\mho))$, is the Prenex* form of $\neg\,\mathrm{dual}(\mho)$. It instantiates the two universal quantifiers at $\bar{p}$ and $\ulcorner\mho\urcorner$ (rule 7), removes the double negation (rule 2), branches (rules 2–4), and closes every branch against (i)–(iii). If (i)–(iii) are carried as U_1^* intermediate theorems with a vacuous universal quantifier, as Willard's own bounded intermediate (28) must be, it instantiates those first (rule 7).

Part (iv) mentions $\bar{p}$ and $\ulcorner\mho\urcorner$ a bounded number of times. Also $\ulcorner\mho\urcorner < p$: p's last root $\mathrm{dual}(\mho)$ is a contiguous part of p, one byte longer than $\mho$ and beginning with a symbol byte, so by the encoding of §2, $\ulcorner\mho\urcorner < 64^{|\mho|} \leq \ulcorner\mathrm{dual}(\mho)\urcorner \leq p$. So the logarithm of (iv)'s Gödel number is $O(\mathrm{Log}\, p)$. The repair then needs (i)–(iii) to be short enough that Corollary 1's bound $F(p,t) < 2^b_a$ survives. Lemma 3's sketch supplies (i). Parts (ii) and (iii) are claims of the same kind, about short proofs of polynomial-time-checkable bounded facts, which the sketch does not address. At this essay's granularity, then, Willard's printed proof of Theorem 6 has a gap at step (31), and our repair is a sketch resting on Lemma 3's sketch and on the length claims for (ii) and (iii). We count Theorem 6 as a `sketch` here, although the registry records it as `full`.

Willard calls the length estimate "quite routine" (p. 36). He measures the difference between the two systems by a constant: proof lengths in $\mathrm{NS}^{k,m}_D(A)$ and $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ differ by at most some $C > 2^m_k$, "an enormous quantity" (p. 31). Why the argument does not transfer to $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ can be seen with Willard's own engine (our observation). Under the hypothesis of Theorem J(a) with $A = \mathrm{PA}+$, all axioms of $\mathrm{IS}_D(\mathrm{PA}+)$ are true Π_1^* sentences: Group-3 by Theorems 3 and 5. So the system is Normed$(a,1)$ for every $a > 1$. $\mathrm{IS}_D(\mathrm{PA}+)$ must prove $\Upsilon(k,m)$ as a lemma. Let $p > 1$ be a proof of it, and take $a = p$. Then $p \leq \lceil a/1 \rceil + 1$, and θ-compactification with $\theta = \frac{1}{4}$ (Theorems 2 and 4) makes $\Upsilon(k,m)$ App$\exists(p^{1/4})$-valid: it has a witness at most $p^{1/4}$. The least witness is 2^m_k, so $p \geq (2^m_k)^4$. In a tableau list, the components up to the lemma form a list proof of it, and they

are a prefix of the whole list's byte string, so the whole list has a Gödel number at least p. That lies far beyond the bound 2^m_{k-1} of which $\mho(k-1,m)$ speaks. "A Kleene-like Group-3 axiom has a different connotation when it refers to a short proof, referencing itself, than when it refers to a long such proof" (p. 32, text layer). The asymmetry is exact: adding a true Π^*_1 sentence instead of the Σ^*_1 sentence $\Upsilon(k,m)$ preserves consistency (p. 37, stated as a generalization of Theorem 5). A universal axiom constrains; an existential axiom supplies a number, and the number is what the faith step was missing. Remark 8 (p. 36, `stated-only`) extends the theorem to semantic tableaux and other cut-free methods, to empty A, and to systems that drop the two Group-zero axioms declaring addition and doubling total.

9 The Price of Faith

If withholding faith is what lets $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ survive, the second incompleteness theorem should return as soon as the system can afford the transcripts. Willard spent the second half of his career proving that it does. The price depends on the language and on how much the proof system may reuse.

Squaring

Give a tableau system multiplication as a total function. Then a proof can introduce $u_0 = 2$, $u_{i+1} = u_i \cdot u_i$, and so reach $u_n = 2^{2^n}$, in $O(n)$ steps. The 2001 system with multiplication added, ISMULT(A), "satisfies an analogue of" Assertion ++ but has no analogue of Lemma 4.2, for exactly this reason (2001, Remark 4.5, p. 21). On the negative side Willard located the failure precisely (2000, §5, quoted in the codified statement §5.3):

> Many readers will smile with amusement when they learn the true reason that the Semantic Tableaux version of the Second Incompleteness Theorem breaks down when Multiplication is changed from a total function into a 3-way relation. It is essentially that Lemma 8 and its short proof then become no longer valid. ... Without it, our proof of the Semantic Tableaux version of the Second Incompleteness Theorem collapses entirely!

Lemma 8 (2000, p. 11, `full`) is the squaring construction: a tableau proof from $Q + V$, of length $O([\log\log z]^C)$, that a number about as large as z exists. With it, the second theorem comes back, at Level(0−):

- no consistent *finite* extension of $Q + V$, for an explicit Π_1 sentence V with $Q + V$ consistent, proves its own semantic tableaux consistency (2002a, Theorems 3.4–3.5, p. 11, `full`);
- every consistent extension of T-1 or T-2, the textbook and Wilkie–Paris axiomatizations of $I\Sigma_0$, is unable to prove its own semantic tableaux consistency (2007, Theorem 6, p. 29, `full`);
- any consistent extension of $I\Sigma_0$ with the Conventional Deciphering Property (a finite subset proves, of each axiom's canonical numeral, that it is an axiom: 2002a, Definition 5.1, p. 20) cannot prove that there is no tableau proof of $0 = 1$ from itself (2002a, Theorem 6.4, p. 25, `sketch`).

In 1981 Paris and Wilkie asked whether $I\Sigma_0$ satisfies the second incompleteness theorem for cut-free deduction. 2002a presented Theorem 6.4 as an answer; 2007 records that the 2002 paper covered only the textbook induction scheme ("which we did not examine in our year-2002 article", of the Wilkie–Paris scheme: 2007, abstract, text layer), and its Theorem 6 covers both. On the positive side, Definition 5 becomes "impossible to satisfy" once multiplication is admitted as a ninth function

symbol (2005, Remark 4, p. 21, `stated-only` as to the reason: "intuitively because multiplication has a faster growth property than addition").[1]

Subroutines

A Hilbert-style proof can prove a lemma once and use it many times. Modus ponens is a subroutine call. A tableau cannot do this; every use must be inlined. Inlining can be astronomically expensive: by Gentzen, the tableau proof exists, but "t's length can certainly be super-exponentially longer" than the proofs it combines (2002a, Theorem 2.2, p. 7, `sketch`), and Boolos gave a famous small example of the blowup [Boolos 1984]. With subroutines, a little growth is amplified into a lot. Willard saw this in 1994 (TR 93-10, p. 7, verbatim):

> These metaphors lose meaning when cuts are present because Addition can then be employed to *implicitly define* a sequence that grows actually faster than $a_0, a_1, a_2, a_3 \ldots$. Solovay's proof that IS(A) is incompatible with deductive cuts [So94] rests on this fast growth property. (Actually, IS(A) can support a cut rule for Δ_0 sentences, and Solovay's theorem relies on the cut rule for sentences with unbounded quantifiers.)

The boundary depends on the *complexity* of the lemmas, and Willard mapped it:

- a cut rule for bounded (Δ_0) sentences: compatible with IS(A), as the parenthesis above says (TR 93-10, p. 7; the codification records the construction in a footnote on p. 35, obligation O56);
- lemmas with one unbounded quantifier block (Π_1^* or Σ_1^*), addition total: self-justifying at Level(1) (2005, Theorem 5, `full`);
- lemmas with two blocks (Π_2^*, respectively Σ_2^*), addition total: for explicit Π_1^* theorems V_A, V_B of Peano Arithmetic, no consistent system in the U-Grounding language containing V_A (resp. V_B) proves its own Level(0−) consistency under Tab−Π_2^* (resp. Tab−Σ_2^*) lists (2004, Theorem 2, p. 344, `sketch`; stated for finite systems "for the sake of simplifying our proof");
- unrestricted lemmas (Hilbert deduction), successor total together with the Π_1 algebra of $+$ and $\times$: Solovay's theorem below.

The unrestricted case runs through the classical shortening of definable cuts. In outline (a textbook gloss, not Willard's text): with lemmas, one defines a set of numbers and proves once that it is closed under successor; then, by a short proof reusing that lemma, that a smaller set is closed under addition, and then that a smaller set still is closed under multiplication. On the last set the system can afford transcripts, and Gödel's argument runs there. Pudlák showed that a consistent extension of Robinson's Q proves neither its Hilbert consistency nor its consistency restricted to any definable cut [Pudlák 1985] (Willard 2006a, Theorem 1, p. 4, `cited`). Solovay's theorem, communicated to Willard by telephone in April 1994 and never published by Solovay, states the conclusion (2006a, Theorem 2, p. 4, `cited`): a consistent system that formalizes arithmetic with three-place predicates for $+$ and $\times$, proves successor total, and proves the Π_1 associative, commutative, distributive and identity laws for those predicates cannot prove that there is no Hilbert proof of $0 = 1$ from itself. With unrestricted subroutines, the price of faith falls to successor together with the ring laws for $+$ and $\times$ as relations: neither addition nor multiplication need be total.

[1] What multiplication destroys is the flat consistency axiom and canonical reflection, not every self-referential construction. Willard's ISM(A) recognizes multiplication as total and is consistent whenever A is regularly consistent, "by a routine generalization" of his proof, but its self-referential axiom is weaker, and it cannot prove the flat statement that no tableau proof of $0 = 1$ exists (2001, §6, p. 36; codified statement §7.2).

So the Hilbert-line self-justifying systems give up successor itself. They name numbers with constants $C_1, C_2, \ldots$, and the naming convention *is* the system (codified statement §5.5). Incremental naming $C_i = C_{i-1} + 1$ is how 2006a reads 2001's ISREF(A), which is consistent when A is regularly consistent (2001, Theorem 3.4, p. 13, `full`) and whose Group-3 is the tangibility schema (2001, Eq. 10), not a flat consistency axiom: "The term 'incremental naming convention' had not appeared in our article [46]. However, its Theorem 3.4 had implicitly presumed the presence of an incremental naming method" (2006a, p. 22, text layer). Additive naming $C_i = C_{i-1} + C_{i-1}$ works and keeps reaching new numbers (ISCE(A), for consistent A with true Π_1^- theorems and Δ_0^- Hilbert proof predicate: 2006a, Theorem 3, p. 6, `full`); multiplicative naming $C_i = C_{i-1} \cdot C_{i-1}$ fails for any system that contains the convention's axioms, proves Peano Arithmetic's Π_1^- theorems and has Willard's Concise Encoding property (2006a, Theorem 4, p. 7, `full`). Remark 3, quoted in §4, explains why.

Other ways to buy faith

Excluded middle as a logical axiom, $\Phi \vee \neg\Phi$ at any node for any Φ (Xtab, 2020, p. 10), is what TR 93-10 had already defined as "a tableaux proof with cuts" (printed p. 33, as recorded in codified statement §7.3). Then $\mathrm{IS}_{\mathrm{Xtab}}(\beta)$ is automatically inconsistent whenever β proves the usual Π_1^* associative, commutative, distributive and identity laws for addition and multiplication (2020, Theorem 4.5, p. 12, `sketch`). And letting $\ddot{\mathrm{W}}$ say more about itself brings the second theorem back: there is a Π_1^* theorem W of Peano Arithmetic such that no consistent finite system in the U-Grounding language containing W can prove its own Level(2^+) tableaux consistency, the absence of proofs of a Boolean combination of Π_2^* and Σ_2^* sentences together with its negation (2004, Theorem 1, p. 342, `full`, although the codification records that one step is deferred, in a footnote saying it "should not be considered a formal proof": codified statement §7.5).

Proof system	Growth	Consistency asserted	Outcome	Source, status
tableaux, or lists of Π_1^*/Σ_1^* lemmas	$+$ total, $\times$ a relation	Level(1)	self-justifying	2005 Thms 3, 5, `full`
same	same, plus one axiom $\exists z\, \mathrm{Log}^k z \geq m$	Level(1)	inconsistent	2005 Thm 6, `full` as printed; `sketch` here (step (31), §8)
tableaux	$\times$ total	Level(0−)	G2	2002a Thm 3.5 `full`; 6.4 `sketch`; 2007 Thm 6 `full`
lists of Π_2^* or Σ_2^* lemmas	$+$ total	Level(0−)	G2	2004 Thm 2, `sketch`
tableaux	$+$ total	Level(2^+)	G2	2004 Thm 1, `full` (one deferred step)
tableaux + excluded middle	$+$ total, $\times$ laws	Level(1)	inconsistent	2020 Thm 4.5, `sketch`
Hilbert	successor total, Π_1 laws of $+$, $\times$	Level(0−)	G2	Solovay, `cited`
Hilbert	additive names only	Level(0−)	self-justifying	2006a Thm 3, `full`
Hilbert	multiplicative names	Level(0−)	G2	2006a Thm 4, `full`

Read the table as Willard read it. Negative rows assert the weakest consistency notion and positive rows the strongest, by the rule of §2, so each row is as strong as its side allows. "Self-justifying" in a positive row means that the system proves its own consistency and is consistent under the

hypothesis on its base theory (Theorem J; 2006a, Theorem 3). The affirmative results are mostly `full`; the negative side contains sketches and one unpublished theorem. The boundary is sharply located in some coordinates and only bracketed in others (codified statement §8.2).

10 Trust Within Reach

A system *trusts* its proofs if it proves canonical reflection, $\forall y \{\mathrm{Prf}_\alpha(\ulcorner \Psi \urcorner, y) \supset \Psi\}$, for every Π_1-class Ψ. That is too much to ask: 2001 Theorem 7.2 (§7) forbids it for any consistent system with a bounded proof predicate that inherits the Π_1^- theorems of PAX. What Willard's systems can prove is *tangibility reflection* (2001, Definition 1.2, p. 4, Eq. 2):

$$\forall x \, \{ \, [\exists y \, \mathrm{Prf}_\alpha(\ulcorner \Psi \urcorner, y) \wedge \mathit{Tangible}(x)] \supset \Psi^x \, \},$$

where Ψ^x is Ψ with its unbounded universal quantifiers bounded by x, and *Tangible* is one of $\mathit{TangPred}(x) \equiv \exists v \, x < v - 1$, $\mathit{TangDiv}_k(x) \equiv \exists v \, x < v/k$, or $\mathit{TangRoot}_k(x) \equiv \exists v \, x < v^{1/k}$. ISREF($A$), a Hilbert-style system without addition total, proves the *TangPred* form for every prenex* Ψ, given that $\forall y \, \mathit{Size}(y) < y - 1$ (2001, Theorem 3.5, p. 14, `full`). The tableau system IS$^\lambda(A)$ has a Hilbert proof of the $\mathit{TangRoot}_k$ form when $0 < \lambda < 1$, $k > 1/(1 - \lambda)$, and A proves a stated Π_1^- sentence (Theorem 6.1, p. 34, `full`), and a tableau proof by cut elimination (Corollary 6.2, p. 35, `full`); its consistency is proved for $\lambda = 3/4$ (Theorem 5.1, p. 28, `full`), where the condition reads $k > 4$. In computational terms: *I trust my verdicts on every input for which there is memory to spare.* For a Σ_1-class claim the bound costs nothing, since $\Psi \equiv \Psi^0$; taking Ψ to be $0 = 1$ gives back the flat statement that no proof of $0 = 1$ exists (2001, p. 8).

11 Taking Off the Glasses

Oberhoff's §5 takes the glasses off $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ and finds "I am not provable" underneath. Take them off $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ and you find "nothing refutes me", that is, "I am consistent". Over extensions of $I\Sigma_1$ with Hilbert deduction, the metatheory shows that $\mathcal{F}_0 + \ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ derives a contradiction (Proposition I), so $\mathsf{C}(\mathsf{C})$ halts. In Willard's systems that refutation would have to establish the existence of a transcript-sized object from inside a proof smaller than the object. The snake cannot swallow its tail, because its mouth is smaller than its body.

So self-reference is not where the trouble lies. The fixed point builds $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ in Willard's systems as easily as in Peano Arithmetic. What costs something is *self-simulation*: running yourself in your head and writing down the result. The second incompleteness theorem needs both. The first needs self-reference and watching, and, in Rosser's form, one Π_1 fact about a loop. That is why Willard's systems obey it.

Oberhoff found that his classical and computational proofs were "the exact same". The same holds here. Willard's arithmetic (a least pair of contradictory proofs, values below $b \cdot 2^{\text{U-Depth}}$, five bits per symbol) and the computational picture (a shortest refutation, the memory a proof occupies, a walk down the tree) are one argument. The arithmetic of Gödel numbers is the bookkeeping of memory.

12 Refactoring the Incompleteness Theorems, Again

Oberhoff's Theorem 7 is two theorems. Stated as properties of a configuration (α, D), they are as follows. Property 7a is what this essay takes from Oberhoff's Theorem 7. Property 7b, in both its closed and its uniform form, is the essay's own formulation of what his Theorem 6 takes on faith.

7a (Watching, Definition C). $\alpha \vdash_D \sigma$ *for every true* Σ_1*-class sentence* σ*; in particular, for the halting sentence of each halting computation.*

7b (Knowing that one watches, Definition D and §4). $\alpha \vdash_D \sigma \supset \mathrm{Prov}_\alpha^D(\ulcorner\sigma\urcorner)$ *for every* Σ_1*-class sentence* σ*; and uniformly,* $\alpha \vdash_D \forall x\,[\delta(x) \supset \mathrm{Prov}_\alpha^D(\textit{the code of } \delta(\bar{x}))]$ *for bounded* δ*.*

Property 7a holds for every configuration in this essay: for extensions of Robinson's Q with Hilbert deduction (standard), for $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ (Lemma K), and for $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ with $A \supseteq \mathrm{PAX}$ (§6). Property 7b, in both forms, holds for recursively axiomatized extensions of $I\Sigma_1$ with their canonical provability predicate [Hájek–Pudlák 1993]. Property 7a gives Oberhoff's Theorem 4 and the $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ half of his §4. Rosser's form also needs the Π_1 loop sentence of footnote 12, which Willard's systems get from their base theory (§6). Property 7b is what Theorem 6 takes on faith, and it does not follow from 7a:

- In its uniform form, 7b fails for both of Willard's systems, under the hypotheses of their consistency theorems: they cannot prove even that every number has a written name (Corollary H).
- At a closed sentence, 7b fails for $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ under the hypotheses of Corollary N. The sentence is H, the Σ_1 statement that $\mathsf{P}(\mathsf{P})$ halts, and the failing instance is provably equivalent to the Gödel sentence (Proposition M).
- For $\mathrm{IS}(A)$, under the hypotheses of Corollary O, either step (2), and with it 7b at H, fails, or the Level$(0-)$ form of step (3) does. We do not know which.

By Lemma E(a) these systems satisfy 7b at every *true* Σ_1-class sentence, so the closed failure is confined to a run that does not happen. The uniform failure is about writing numbers down, which costs more than linearly many bits. Willard's Theorem 6 (§8) shows a bounded transcript form of 7b, at "$\mho$ is provable", to be a Π_1^* theorem of PA+, inherited through Group-2. With Definition 6 repaired as sketched there, its transcript reaches the sentence Pair pairs with $\mho$. What the system lacks is one number large enough to switch it on, and granting that number as an axiom makes the system inconsistent.

So Gödel's work splits into three parts, not two. The first is programming the integers (7a). The second is teaching the integers that they have been programmed (7b). The third is the victory laps. Willard's self-justifying systems live in the gap between the first and the second. The second incompleteness theorem is a victory lap only for a runner who has already paid for 7b. Willard's accounting does not give one price. It gives four boundaries (§9):

- tableaux without lemmas, multiplication total: the second theorem holds at Level$(0-)$ for consistent finite extensions of $Q + V$ and for consistent extensions of $I\Sigma_0$'s two axiomatizations (2002a, Theorem 3.5; 2007, Theorem 6; `full`);
- lemmas with one unbounded quantifier block, addition total and multiplication a relation: $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ is self-justifying at Level(1), and consistent whenever A's Π_1^* theorems are true (2005, Theorem 5, `full`);
- lemmas with two blocks, addition total: for explicit Π_1^* theorems V_A, V_B of Peano Arithmetic, no consistent finite system containing V_A (respectively V_B) proves its own Level$(0-)$ consistency under Π_2^* (respectively Σ_2^*) lemma lists (2004, Theorem 2, `sketch`; finiteness "for the sake of simplifying our proof");
- unrestricted lemmas: successor total together with the Π_1 ring laws for $+$ and $\times$ as relations already suffices (Solovay, `cited`).

At the finest grain, one large number granted as an axiom is enough (2005, Theorem 6, a `sketch` at this granularity).

Moral of the story: you may declare yourself a very stable genius, and Willard's theorems will vouch for you provided your teachers told you only truths, you cannot multiply, and you reuse only lemmas with one unbounded quantifier block. Learn to multiply, and (for the theories Willard treats) even proofs without lemmas are too much. Reuse lemmas with two blocks, and (by a sketch of Willard's) addition is already too much. Reuse any lemma you like, and (by Solovay's unpublished theorem) successor with the ring laws for $+$ and $\times$ is too much. And you must never be told, as an axiom, that a big enough number exists.

13 What Self-Justification Does Not Buy

Willard was more careful about the limits of his results than most of his readers have been, and an honest retelling must carry his caveats.

- **Relative consistency.** Theorem J assumes that the base theory's Π_1-class theorems are true. Nothing here shows any system consistent outright; the systems are as trustworthy as their base. Willard: "if A = Peano Arithmetic, IS(A) can prove all the Π_1^- theorems of Peano Arithmetic, and its consistency will be as certain as that of Peano Arithmetic!" (2001, p. 11, text layer).

- **A reduced question.** Willard (2016, Remark 4.9, p. 13) splits Hilbert's question in two: can a system verify its own consistency in a robust sense, and "Can logic systems 'appreciate' their own consistency in some REDUCED sense, that is diluted but not fully immaterial?" (text layer). The answer to the first is no, by Gödel, Hilbert–Bernays and Pudlák–Solovay. Everything above answers the second.

- **A one-line proof.** A system that proves its consistency from its own axiom $\ddot{\mathsf{W}}$ has "essentially a 1-line proof" (2011, Remark 6.16, p. 28), which is instinctive faith rather than proof-justification. The substantive justification lies outside: the theorem that *Probe* defeats every refutation, proved in the metatheory under the hypothesis on A.

- **Almost cheating.** Willard raised the objection against himself: "Is it not almost cheating when an axiom system verifies its own consistency by using $\oplus$'s formalized 'I am consistent' axiom as an intermediate step, to verify its own consistency? After all, such a technique can verify its own consistency only in a technically purely legalistic sense" (2016, §8). His answer, *Platonic Stability*, is that a thinking being needs no sophisticated justification of its own reasoning, only a formalism in which presuming its own consistency provably will not spin it into inconsistency. Its formal statement, Corollary 8.2 (p. 28), opens "Let us assume Conjecture 6.6 is correct (as we are almost 100 % certain it is)"; Conjecture 6.6 (p. 23) is `stated-only`.

- **The first theorem stands.** Under the hypothesis of Theorem J(a), with A proving the Π_1^* theorems of PA+, $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ decides neither $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ nor $\ddot{\mathsf{R}}$. $\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ is unprovable by Corollary N(a), $\neg\ddot{\mathsf{G}}$ by honesty (Lemma L(a)), and Rosser's form holds by §6. The same holds for $\mathrm{IS}(A)$ with $A \supseteq$ PAX regularly consistent (Corollary O, Lemma L(b)), as Willard said in 1994: it satisfies "Godel's First but not Second Incompleteness Theorem" (TR 93-10, p. 6).

- **Interpretation versus source.** The vocabulary of watching and knowing, the conventions of §2 (the least-witness substitution, the unbounded fixed point, the Prenex* rewriting, Pair and the numbering of sentences), Proposition G and its corollary, the program C as a reading

of Willard's Group-3, the horizon picture, Lemmas E–L, Proposition M and its corollaries, the reading of Willard's Theorem 6 as Oberhoff's Theorem 6 with the faith supplied, and the repair of its fourth step are ours, not Willard's formulations. His own words for the mechanism are "adequate memory" (1994) and the comparison, in 2006a Remark 3, between a proof's Gödel number and the integer the proof shows to exist.

(The cake promised in Oberhoff's abstract is still on its way. We cannot prove that it exists: it is one multiplication away.)

A Provenance

Page numbers are the printed page numbers of the author copies held in `nachlass/papers/` in the repository; for 2004 they are the volume's. The PDF page index differs for TR 93-10 (by 2), for 2011, 2016 and 2020 (by 1) and for 2004, and the codification sometimes cites the index instead. Statuses are those of `nachlass/codification/registry/results.md`. "Verbatim, image" marks quotations checked against rendered page images; "text layer" marks quotations checked only against the extracted text.

Paper	Item	Page	Content used here	Status
TR 93-10	—	6	philosopher's hedge; G1 but not G2; "either fails ... or fails to meet"; *Turing*(x, y, z)	verbatim, image
TR 93-10	—	7	adequate memory; a_{300}; cuts and Solovay	verbatim, image
TR 93-10	—	33	tableaux with $\Phi \vee \neg\Phi$ (Xtab)	via codified §7.3
2000	Lem 8; §5	11; —	squaring construction; "the true reason"	full; verbatim (codified §5.3)
2001	Def 1.2	4	tangibility predicates, Eq. 2	—
2001	§2	9–12	grounding functions; IS(A) groups; regular consistency	text layer
2001	Thm 3.4, 3.5	13–14	ISREF(A) consistency; *TangPred* reflection	full
2001	Lem 4.1, 4.2	17, 19	constants below $\sqrt{y}$; parameters below y	full; sketch
2001	Thm 4.3; Rem 4.4	20	IS(A) consistency; Assertion ++	full; verbatim, image
2001	Rem 4.5	21	ISMULT(A) has no analogue of Lem 4.2	—
2001	Lem 4.6, 4.8	22–23	affirmative branch cannot close; least refutation has one	full
2001	Case 11	28	"substantially more than six bits"	image (extraction record)
2001	Thm 5.1, 6.1; Cor 6.2	28, 34–35	$\mathrm{IS}^{\lambda}(A)$ at $\lambda = 3/4$; *TangRoot*$_k$ reflection	full
2001	§6	36	ISM(A)	routine generalization (Willard)
2001	Lem 7.1; Thm 7.2, 7.3	37–40	closure; no canonical reflection, fixed point (63), (67), (U); XIS^{λ}	full; text layer
2001	App B	51–52	byte encoding of proofs; sentences numbered by byte value; constants	text layer
2001	Thm C.1–C.3	56–60	arithmetization via LinH	sketch; full given C.1–C.2
2002a	Thm 2.2	7	cut elimination, super-exponential length	sketch
2002a	Thm 3.4, 3.5	11	$Q + V$: G2 for finite extensions, tableaux	full
2002a	Def 5.1; Thm 6.4	20, 25	Conventional Deciphering; $I\Sigma_0$	—; sketch
2002c	—	2	weakest notion for G2, strongest for exceptions	via obligation O59
2004	Thm 1, 2	342, 344	Level(2^+) G2; Π_2^*/Σ_2^* lemmas	full (deferred step); sketch
2005	§1	—	Kleene, Rogers, Jeroslow	verbatim (codified §2.2)
2005	§2–3	4–10	U-Grounding language; Level notions; tableaux; Tab lists; $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$; Eqs. 5–8	text layer
2005	Def 4, 5; Thm 1	19–20	Normed, θ-compactification; engine; j_2 proves "the Σ_1^* theorem that is Φ's negation"	full; text layer
2005	Rem 2, 4	21	2001 proof hard to visualize; multiplication	—; stated-only
2005	Lem 1, 2; Thm 2	23–26	*Probe*; non-closure; $\theta = 1/4$; Eq. 20	full
2005	fn 3; Thms 3–5; Rem 5; fn 5	26–29	leading negation in neither class; $\mathrm{IS}_D(A)$ consistency-preserving; Part A's U-Height demand	full; text layer
2005	Defs 2, 3, 6; Lem 3, 4; Thm 6	11, 33–36	$\mathrm{NS}_D^{k,m}$; (27)–(33); Def 6's q proves (25), so step (31) needs the repair sketched in §8 (ours)	full as printed; sketch here; Def 6 image
2005	Rem 8; p. 37	36–37	stronger Thm 6; Π_1^* additions	stated-only
2005	§2	6–7	tableau rules; Prenex* root; axioms as nodes; Tab lists; "also hold if we drop the Prenex* requirement"	text layer
2005	App A	39–40	encoding; uncompressed encodings	text layer
2006a	Thms 1, 2	4	Pudlák's and Solovay's theorems	cited
2006a	Thms 3, 4	6–7	additive naming works; multiplicative fails	full
2006a	Rem 3	24	proof's Gödel number vs. the integer it proves exists	verbatim, image
2006a	App A	37	uncompressed encodings "have analogs"	text layer
2007	Thm 6	29	T-1, T-2: G2 for tableaux	full
2011	Rem 6.16	28	"essentially a 1-line proof"	—
2016	Def 3.4, Ex 3.5	7	self-justification; "ironically typically useless"	verbatim (codified §2.2)
2016	Rem 4.9; §8	13; —	the two questions; "almost cheating"	verbatim (codified §1.4)
2016	Conj 6.6; Cor 8.2	23; 28	Platonic Stability, conditional	stated-only; text layer
2020	Xtab; Thm 4.5	10; 12	excluded middle; $\mathrm{IS}_{\mathrm{Xtab}}$ inconsistent	sketch

References

[Oberhoff 2018] S. Oberhoff, *Incompleteness Ex Machina*, essay dated 31 December 2018, `https://www.scottaaronson.com/incompleteness.pdf`.

[Aaronson 2013] S. Aaronson, *Quantum Computing since Democritus*, Cambridge University Press, 2013. (Source of Oberhoff's program B, per his reference [3].)

[Willard TR 93-10] D. E. Willard, *Self-Verifying Axiom Systems and the Incompleteness Theorem*, SUNY Albany Computer Science Technical Report 93-10 (a 1994 text with a 1993 series number).

[Willard 1993] D. E. Willard, Self-verifying axiom systems, in *Computational Logic and Proof Theory (KGC 3)*, LNCS 713, Springer, 1993, pp. 325–336.

[Willard 2000] D. E. Willard, The semantic tableaux version of the second incompleteness theorem extends almost to Robinson's arithmetic Q, in *TABLEAUX 2000*, LNAI 1847, Springer, 2000, pp. 415–430.

[Willard 2001] D. E. Willard, Self-verifying axiom systems, the incompleteness theorem and related reflection principles, *Journal of Symbolic Logic* 66(2) (2001), 536–596.

[Willard 2002a] D. E. Willard, How to extend the semantic tableaux and cut-free versions of the second incompleteness theorem almost to Robinson's arithmetic Q, *Journal of Symbolic Logic* 67 (2002), 465–496.

[Willard 2002c] D. E. Willard, Some new exceptions for the semantic tableaux version of the second incompleteness theorem, in *TABLEAUX 2002*, LNCS 2381, Springer, 2002, pp. 281–297.

[Willard 2004] D. E. Willard, A version of the second incompleteness theorem for axiom systems that recognize addition but not multiplication as a total function, in *First Order Logic Revisited*, Logos Verlag, Berlin, 2004, pp. 337–368.

[Willard 2005] D. E. Willard, An exploration of the partial respects in which an axiom system recognizing solely addition as a total function can verify its own consistency, *Journal of Symbolic Logic* 70 (2005), 1171–1209.

[Willard 2006a] D. E. Willard, A generalization of the second incompleteness theorem and some exceptions to it, *Annals of Pure and Applied Logic* 141 (2006), 472–496.

[Willard 2007] D. E. Willard, Passive induction and a solution to a Paris–Wilkie open question, *Annals of Pure and Applied Logic* 146 (2007), 124–149.

[Willard 2011] D. E. Willard, A detailed examination of methods for unifying, simplifying and extending several results about self-justifying logics, arXiv:1108.6330 (2011).

[Willard 2016] D. E. Willard, On how the introducing of a new θ function symbol into arithmetic's formalism is germane to devising axiom systems that can appreciate fragments of their own Hilbert consistency, arXiv:1612.08071 (2016–2017).

[Willard 2020] D. E. Willard, How the law of excluded middle pertains to the second incompleteness theorem and its boundary-case exceptions, arXiv:2006.01057 (2020).

[Hájek–Pudlák 1993] P. Hájek and P. Pudlák, *Metamathematics of First-Order Arithmetic*, Springer, 1993.

[Hilbert–Bernays 1939] D. Hilbert and P. Bernays, *Grundlagen der Mathematik*, vol. II, Die Grundlehren der mathematischen Wissenschaften 50, Springer, Berlin, 1939.

[Löb 1955] M. H. Löb, Solution of a problem of Leon Henkin, *Journal of Symbolic Logic* 20 (1955), 115–118.

[Pudlák 1985] P. Pudlák, Cuts, consistency statements and interpretations, *Journal of Symbolic Logic* 50 (1985), 423–441.

[Boolos 1984] G. Boolos, Don't eliminate cut, *Journal of Philosophical Logic* 13 (1984), 373–378.